North Carolina Driver Handbook

Questions & Answers Study Guide

778 questions covering the entire handbook

Based on the official NCDMV Driver Handbook (revised May 2025)

Every section of the official NC Driver Handbook (nc-driver-handbook.pdf, 108 pages), turned into questions and answers. The sections follow the handbook's order.

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Introduction & DMV Services

Q **About how many miles of state-maintained roads does North Carolina have?**

A More than 80,000 miles.

Q **About how many licensed drivers are there in North Carolina?**

A About 7.6 million.

Q **About how many crashes and deaths happen on North Carolina roads each year?**

A About 284,000 crashes and nearly 1,700 deaths.

Q **What is the handbook for?**

A To help you get ready for your driver license exam. It covers your new license, safe driving techniques and important rules of the road.

Q **What is DMV directAccess?**

A An automated phone service. It gives information about driver licenses and vehicle registration from NCDOT's Division of Motor Vehicles.

Q **What number do you call for DMV directAccess, and when is it available?**

A 919-715-7000. It is available 24 hours a day, 7 days a week.

Q **What information can DMV directAccess give you?**

A Information about:

- driver licenses, learner permits, motorcycle endorsements, CDLs and ID cards
- points, your driving record and your license status
- medical and vision forms, exam cycles, records and hearings
- vehicle registration, duplicate titles, lost or stolen plates, personalized and vanity plates, and handicapped placards
- liability insurance
- taxes and fees

Q **How can DMV directAccess help you find a nearby office?**

A Enter your zip code, and it gives you the location of a driver license or vehicle registration office in your area.

Q **What are the phone numbers for the Traffic Records Section, the International Registration Plan (IRP) Section and Tag & Tax Together?**

A Traffic Records is 919-615-6131, IRP is 919-615-6700, and Tag & Tax Together is 919-814-1779.

Q **What is the DMV website?**

A NCDMV.gov

Q **Name some services available online.**

A You can:

- pay or estimate vehicle property taxes
- renew a driver license or vehicle registration
- order a duplicate registration card, personalized plates or driving records
- view your MyDMV account
- sign up for email notifications
- pay insurance lapse penalties
- renew commercial carrier registration

Q **What do you need to request a duplicate driver license or ID card online?**

A DMV must have your last photo on file. You also need a valid Social Security number or a U.S. government document showing legal presence.

Q **What are the reasons you can request a duplicate license or ID online?**

A To replace a lost or stolen card, to change your home or mailing address, or to replace a card that is damaged or defaced.

Q **How much does a duplicate license or ID card cost online, and how do you pay?**

A $16.75, paid with any credit or debit card.

Q **How often can you renew your license online?**

A Every other renewal.

Q **How early can you renew your license?**

A Up to six months before it expires.

Q **What must you confirm to renew online?**

A You must confirm:

- your identity
- that you live at the address on the license
- that you have no vision problems that would affect your driving
- that all your statements are true

You also need your current license number and a major credit or debit card.

Q **How long does it take to get a license renewed online, and how long is it valid?**

A It arrives by mail in 7–14 business days. It is valid for 5 or 8 years, depending on your age.

Q **When can you NOT use online renewal?**

A Online renewal can't be used:

- for a first-time license or ID, including a first-time REAL ID
- if your license has any restriction other than corrective lenses
- if you are in the medical review program
- to renew a CDL or a state ID card
- if your license is expired, suspended or revoked

Q **What are some alternatives to driving?**

A Walking, riding a bicycle, carpooling and public transportation.

Q **Is public transportation available for people with disabilities?**

A Yes. Public transportation is equipped to serve people with disabilities.

Q **What number do you call to learn about public transportation in your area?**

A The NCDOT Public Transportation Division at 919-707-4670.

Chapter 1 — Your License

General

Q **Is driving a right or a privilege?**

A A legal privilege and a responsibility.

Q **Besides driving, what else is illegal without a valid license?**

A Sitting in the driver's seat while the engine is running. Also, steering a vehicle while another vehicle pushes or tows it.

Q **What are the usual hours for driver license offices?**

A 8:00 a.m. to 5:00 p.m., Monday through Friday. Offices in smaller towns may be open only on certain days.

Q **Where can you make an appointment for a driver license exam? Do you need one?**

A Online at skiptheline.ncdot.gov. You don't need an appointment. Walk-ins are accepted all day, or until the office is full.

Q **What can you be tested on for an original driver license?**

A Vision, traffic signs, knowledge of motor vehicle laws, and driving skill (an on-road test).

Learner Permits

Q **Who can get a regular learner permit?**

A People age 18 and older.

Q **What must a learner permit holder have with them while driving on the highway?**

A A person licensed to drive that vehicle, seated beside the permit holder.

Q **What tests are required for a learner permit?**

A Vision, traffic signs, and knowledge of motor vehicle laws.

Q **What do you need to get a motorcycle learner permit if you are 16 or 17?**

A A full provisional license and a parent's or guardian's signature. You must also complete the Motorcycle Safety Foundation Basic Rider Course or the NC Motorcycle Safety Education Program Basic Rider Course.

Q **What do you need to get a motorcycle learner permit if you are 18 or older?**

A A license issued by the Division (DMV).

Q **Can you carry passengers with a motorcycle learner permit?**

A No. It allows you to ride only without passengers.

Q **How long is a motorcycle learner permit valid?**

A 12 months. You can renew it once for six more months.

Q What tests are required for a motorcycle learner permit?

A Vision, traffic signs, and the motorcycle knowledge test.

Q Which handbook should you study for a motorcycle endorsement?

A The Motorcycle Handbook.

Q Which handbook should you study for a CDL?

A The CDL Handbook. It is available from the Federal Motor Carrier Safety Administration, on the DMV website and at driver license offices.

Q Must each driver license test be passed separately?

A Yes.

Test Requirements

Q When is your vision checked?

A When you apply in person for a learner permit, an original license or a renewal.

Q What happens if you need corrective lenses to pass the vision test?

A You must wear them every time you drive. Your license will show a corrective lens restriction.

Q What is the penalty for driving without your required corrective lenses?

A The same as driving without a license.

Q What must you do to pass the traffic signs test?

A Identify traffic signs by their color and shape, and explain what each one means.

Q What is the knowledge test about?

A Traffic laws and safe driving practices.

Q Is there help for people who have trouble reading the knowledge test?

A Yes. Audio tests are available if you ask.

Q When do you take the driving skills (road) test?

A After you pass all the other tests. It is required the first time you apply for a license. You might also have to take it when you renew. It is not required for a learner permit.

Q Can someone with a disability get a license?

A Yes. They may get a restricted license, as long as the condition doesn't keep them from driving safely.

Q Why might a person be denied a license for health reasons?

A If they have a mental or physical condition that might keep them from driving safely.

Q **What skills are graded on the road test?**

A The examiner grades:

- approaching intersections, stop signs and signals
- quick stops
- backing
- stopping, starting and parking
- using the clutch (in standard-transmission cars)
- turn signals and the horn
- turning
- lane use
- following other vehicles
- passing and being passed
- yielding the right of way
- driving posture
- the three-point turnabout

Q **What is a "quick stop" on the road test?**

A Stopping as quickly and safely as you can when the examiner tells you to.

Q **What are the steps of a three-point turnabout?**

A

1. Start from the far right side of the road. Check for traffic, signal left, and move forward slowly while turning the wheel left. Stop a few inches from the left curb or edge.
2. Back up slowly while turning the wheel right. Stop a few inches from the right curb or edge.
3. Move forward slowly while turning the wheel left to finish the turn.

Types of Licenses

Q **What are the two main types of driver licenses in North Carolina?**

A A regular driver license and a commercial driver license (CDL).

Q **What decides which class of license you need?**

A The type of vehicle you will drive. You must take the skills test in a vehicle that matches that class.

Q **What does a Regular Class A license allow?**

A Driving a combination of vehicles that is exempt from CDL requirements, when the towed unit has a GVWR of 10,001 pounds or more.

Q **What does a Regular Class B license allow?**

A Driving a CDL-exempt single vehicle with a GVWR of 26,001 pounds or more. It also covers that vehicle towing a vehicle of 10,000 pounds GVWR or less.

Q **What does a Regular Class C license allow?**

A Driving a noncommercial single vehicle with a GVWR under 26,001 pounds. Drivers 18 or older may also tow, as long as the combined GVWR is under 26,001 pounds.

Q What license do most drivers need for cars and small trucks?

A A Regular Class C license.

Q What does GVWR stand for?

A Gross Vehicle Weight Rating.

Q Who needs a CDL?

A Drivers, paid or volunteer, of certain vehicles designed or used to carry passengers or property.

Q What is a Class A commercial motor vehicle?

A A combination of vehicles with a combined GVWR of at least 26,001 pounds, where the towed unit has a GVWR of at least 10,001 pounds.

Q What is a Class B commercial motor vehicle?

A Either a single vehicle with a GVWR of at least 26,001 pounds, or a towing unit of at least 26,001 pounds GVWR pulling a towed unit under 10,001 pounds.

Q What is a Class C commercial motor vehicle?

A A vehicle not in Class A or B that either is designed to carry 16 or more passengers (counting the driver) or carries hazardous materials that require placards.

Q Which vehicles do NOT need a CDL?

A Recreational vehicles, military equipment, fire and emergency equipment, and certain farm vehicles. You still need a regular license of the right class.

Q Can volunteer firefighters, rescue or EMS members drive Class A, B or C emergency vehicles without a CDL?

A Yes, while on duty, if they hold a Regular A, B or C license.

Q Which jobs need a special CDL endorsement?

A Hauling hazardous materials, carrying passengers, driving school buses or school activity buses, pulling double trailers, and driving tank vehicles.

Endorsements

Q What do you need to ride a motorcycle on public roads?

A A regular or commercial license with a motorcycle endorsement, or a motorcycle learner permit.

Q What are the requirements to drive a school bus?

A You must:

- be at least 18
- have at least six months of driving experience
- hold a Class B or C CDL with "S" (school bus) and "P" (passenger) endorsements
- have a School Bus Driver's Certificate

Q How do you get a School Bus Driver's Certificate?

A Complete special training and pass an exam given by a Driver Education Program Specialist.

Q How are the requirements for a school activity bus driver different?

A They are the same, except you don't need a School Bus Driver's Certificate.

Q Who can NOT get a CDL with a "P" or "S" endorsement?

A Anyone required to register under the sex offender and public protection registration programs (G.S. 20-37.14A).

Graduated Licensing (Ages 15–18)

Q At what age can you apply for a Level One Limited Learner Permit?

A At 15, after finishing an approved driver education course. You must be under 18 and live in North Carolina.

Q What must the driver education course include?

A At least 30 hours of classroom instruction and 6 hours of behind-the-wheel instruction.

Q What tests are required for a Level One permit?

A Written, sign and vision tests.

Q What hours can you drive in the first six months of a Level One permit?

A Between 5 a.m. and 9 p.m., with your supervising driver.

Q What changes after six months on a Level One permit?

A You can drive at any time, as long as your supervising driver is with you.

Q How long must you hold a Level One permit before applying for a Limited Provisional License?

A Nine months.

Q How many hours must the Driving Log show, and how many must be at night?

A At least 60 hours total, with at least 10 at night.

Q What counts as nighttime driving for the log?

A Driving after sunset, during the hours when there is no daylight. Daytime driving is from sunrise to sunset, while daylight lasts.

Q Who signs the Driving Log, and when do you turn it in?

A Your supervising driver signs it. You turn it in when you apply for the Limited Provisional License.

Q Who may sit in the front seat with a Level One permit holder?

A Only the driver and the supervising driver.

Q Must all passengers wear seat belts with a Level One permit?

A Yes. Every passenger must use a seat belt or child safety seat.

Q **Can Level One, Level Two or under-18 Level Three drivers use a cell phone while driving?**

A No, except to call about an emergency. Allowed calls are to:

- an emergency response operator
- a hospital, doctor's office or health clinic
- an ambulance company
- a fire department
- a law enforcement agency
- your parent, legal guardian or spouse

Q **What must your record show before you can move from Level One to Level Two, or from Level Two to Level Three?**

A No convictions for moving violations, seat belt violations or cell phone violations in the past six months.

Q **Who can be a supervising driver?**

A A parent, grandparent or guardian, or a responsible person the parent or guardian approves. They must hold a valid license and have been licensed for at least five years.

Q **How old must you be for a Level Two Limited Provisional License?**

A At least 16, but under 18.

Q **When can you drive alone with a Level Two license?**

A From 5 a.m. to 9 p.m. You can also drive at any time when going straight to or from work, or to or from volunteer fire, rescue or EMS service if you are a member.

Q **How long must you hold a Level Two license before applying for a Full Provisional License?**

A At least six months.

Q **When supervised on a Level Two license, where must the supervising driver sit?**

A Beside the driver.

Q **What are the passenger limits for a Level Two driver driving alone?**

A The rules are:

- You may carry only one passenger under 21 who is not in your household.
- You may carry one more such passenger if they are a student and you are driving straight to or from school.
- There's no under-21 limit if every passenger lives in your household.
- Under-21 household members may not ride when under-21 non-household members are in the car.

Q **How can you upgrade from Level Two to Level Three?**

A Online, if you are eligible.

Q **What happens when a Level Three driver turns 18?**

A They can upgrade to a regular Class C license online, if eligible.

Q Do the time, supervision and passenger limits apply to a Full Provisional License?

A No.

Q What should a new resident aged 15 to 17 with an out-of-state permit or license do?

A Contact a local driver license office to find out which license or permit they can apply for.

The Provisional Licensee

Q Who is a provisional licensee?

A Any driver under age 18.

Q Why do special laws apply to provisional licensees?

A Because these drivers have a much higher crash rate.

Q How does DMV treat a provisional licensee's driving record?

A It reviews the record more closely. DMV may contact you if you have certain convictions or crashes.

Q What happens if a provisional licensee drives after drinking any amount of alcohol or using drugs?

A It's illegal, and a conviction brings a one-year license revocation.

Q Who must sign for a minor's license?

A A parent or legal guardian.

Q Can a provisional licensee text or read email while driving?

A No.

Q Who must wear a seat belt when a provisional licensee is driving?

A Everyone in the vehicle while it is moving.

Q What school discipline can cause a student to lose their license?

A A suspension of more than 10 days in a row. So can being assigned to an alternative school for more than 10 days in a row for discipline.

Q How long does a "Lose Control/Lose Your License" suspension last?

A 12 months.

Restrictions

Q What are examples of license restrictions?

A Having to wear corrective lenses, or having to use special equipment needed to drive safely.

Q What happens if you drive outside your license restriction?

A You are treated as driving without a license.

Required Documents

Q **Can DMV keep or copy your documents?**

A Yes. It may copy them or hold them briefly to check that they are real. Altered documents are not accepted.

Q **Which laws set the document requirements?**

A NC General Statutes 20-7 and 20-11, and 6 CFR Part 37 of the Federal Register.

Q **What must you prove when applying for a license, permit or ID in North Carolina for the first time?**

A Your full name and date of birth, your NC home address, and your Social Security number or legal presence in the U.S. You also need proof of vehicle liability insurance (for a license).

Q **What does "Not for Federal Identification" on a NC license, permit or ID mean?**

A It is still a valid state license, permit or ID. But starting May 7, 2025, you need extra documents to fly on a commercial airline or to enter federal facilities, military bases or nuclear power plants that require ID.

Q **What extra document must applicants under 18 provide?**

A Proof that they completed a driver education course of 30 hours in the classroom and 6 hours behind the wheel.

Table 1 — Proof of Identity and Date of Birth

Q **Name some documents accepted as proof of identity and date of birth.**

A Accepted documents include:

- a valid U.S. passport
- a certified birth certificate
- a Consular Report of Birth Abroad (FS-240, DS-1350 or FS-545)
- a Permanent Resident Card (I-551)
- an unexpired Employment Authorization Document (I-766 or I-668B)
- a foreign passport with a U.S. visa and an approved I-94
- a Certificate of Naturalization (N-550 or N-570)
- a Certificate of Citizenship (N-560 or N-561)
- a REAL ID license or ID
- a license or state ID from NC, another state, Puerto Rico, a U.S. territory or a Canadian province
- a driving record
- an NC school transcript, diploma or GED
- a U.S. military ID or DD-214
- certified Register of Deeds or court documents (marriage certificate, divorce decree, name change)
- an NC Limited Driving Privilege
- DHS/USCIS documents

Q What are the rules for a birth certificate used as proof of identity?

A It must be a certified copy filed with a state Office of Vital Statistics or a similar agency. Photocopies aren't accepted unless certified by the issuing agency. Laminated copies and plastic replicas aren't accepted either.

Q How long can a license or state ID be expired and still be used as proof of identity?

A Less than 2 years.

Q Which school documents are NOT accepted as proof of identity?

A Driver Education Certificates, Driver Eligibility Certificates and report cards.

Q How long can a Limited Driving Privilege be expired and still be used as proof of identity?

A No more than 1 year.

Q Which court documents can be used as proof of identity?

A Divorce decrees, court orders for a name or gender change, and adoption papers.

Q What happens when your proof is a driving record, school record, military ID or court document?

A The card you get will be marked "Not for Federal Identification." Some of these may still work for REAL ID together with other documents.

Table 2 — Social Security Number

Q What must you provide if you are not eligible for an SSN?

A Documents showing your legal presence in the United States.

Q Which documents prove your Social Security number?

A Accepted documents include:

- a Social Security card (no photocopies or laminated cards)
- a W-2
- an SSA-1099 or non-SSA-1099
- a pay stub with your name and SSN
- a DD-214
- a Social Security document
- a military record showing the full SSN

Q What is required for a W-2, 1099 or pay stub used as proof of SSN?

A It must not be redacted (blacked out), and it must show the full Social Security number.

Q Can you use a Medicaid or Medicare card to prove your SSN?

A No. Social Security numbers were removed from those cards in 2019.

Tables 3 & 4 — Proof of Residency

Q How many proofs of NC residency must adults (18+) show? How many for a REAL ID?

A Two. Under the Modernization Act, only one is needed for a REAL ID.

Q **Name some accepted proofs of residency for adults.**

A Accepted proofs include:

- documents from a U.S., foreign, other-state or NC government agency
- a preprinted bank or corporate statement
- business letterhead
- a pay stub with your address
- a utility bill
- a signed housing contract for an NC address
- personal or real property tax receipts
- a current auto insurance policy with your address
- a monthly or quarterly financial statement
- an NC vehicle registration card or title
- an NC voter precinct card
- NC school records

Q **How many proofs of residency must minors (under 18) show?**

A Two documents showing their permanent NC address. Only one is needed for a REAL ID.

Q **Name some accepted proofs of residency for minors.**

A Accepted proofs include:

- mail from organizations like scouts or sports teams
- NC school records
- magazine subscriptions
- a lease showing the minor as an occupant
- tax records listing the minor as a dependent
- medical records
- a hunting or fishing license
- a Social Security card stub with an address
- a bank statement
- a preprinted business letter
- a letter from a homeless shelter

Tables 5 & 6 — Legal Presence and DACA

Q **Name some documents that prove legal presence.**

A Accepted documents include:

- a Permanent Resident Card (I-551)
- a Machine-Readable Immigrant Visa
- a temporary I-551 stamp
- an Employment Authorization Card (I-766)
- an I-20 or DS-2019 with an I-94 or a stamped foreign passport
- an I-94 record
- a WT/WB admission stamp
- a U.S. passport or passport card
- an I-220B with I-766
- an I-512L
- an unexpired foreign passport with a CBP admission stamp

Q **What documents do DACA applicants use?**

A An Employment Authorization Document showing Category C33, or an I-797 Notice of Action (case type I-821) approval notice with valid "to and from" dates.

Table 7 — Proof of Insurance

Q **What insurance proof do you need for a driver license?**

A Proof of liability insurance in your name from an insurance company licensed in North Carolina. You can use:

- Form DL-123 from your agent
- a policy showing your name and expiration dates
- an insurance binder
- an insurance card with your name, policy number, and issue and expiration dates

Q **Is a digital (phone) proof of insurance accepted?**

A No. You need printed proof.

Table 8 — No-Fee ID Cards

Q **Who can get an ID card for free?**

A Free ID cards are available to:

- people who are homeless (with a letter from their shelter)
- people who are legally blind (with a letter from a doctor)
- people 70 or older
- people at least 17 years old
- people whose license was medically cancelled (it must show on their driving record)
- people with a developmental disability (with a letter from their primary care provider)

Liability Insurance Requirement

Q **Who must show printed proof of liability insurance?**

A People applying for an original license (including out-of-state transfers), people whose license is being restored after a suspension or revocation, and people given a Limited Driving Privilege by a court.

Q **How long are Form DL-123, binders and insurance certificates valid?**

A 30 days from the date they are issued.

Q **What if you don't own a registered vehicle and don't drive other people's private passenger vehicles?**

A You sign a certification of exemption (DL-123A) at the license office. Your license is then restricted to "Fleet Vehicles Only."

Q **How do you remove the "Fleet Vehicles Only" restriction?**

A Pay the $16.75 duplicate fee and show proof of financial responsibility.

Q **What should you get before your visit to avoid problems at the license office?**

A Form DL-123 from your insurance agent.

REAL ID

Q **Which law set stricter security standards for licenses and ID cards?**

A The REAL ID Act of 2005.

Q **How can you tell if a license or ID is a REAL ID?**

A It has a star. Non-REAL IDs say "NOT FOR FEDERAL IDENTIFICATION."

Q **Who is affected by the REAL ID Act?**

A People flying on domestic commercial airlines (including unaccompanied minors under 18). It also affects visitors to federal facilities that require ID, such as military bases, prisons and nuclear power plants.

Q **Can people without a REAL ID still enter federal facilities?**

A Yes, but they must show extra documents. They should contact the agency (such as TSA) ahead of time.

Q **When did NCDMV start issuing REAL IDs?**

A May 2017.

Q **Does a REAL ID cost extra?**

A No. Fees are the same.

Q How do you get a REAL ID?

A Visit a local NCDMV driver license office. You can make an appointment at 919-715-7000 or skiptheline.ncdot.gov, but you don't need one. You must meet all normal license, permit or ID requirements first.

Q Where can you find the full list of REAL ID documents?

A NCREALID.gov

Moving to North Carolina

Q How long does a new resident have to get a NC license or learner permit?

A 60 days after becoming a resident.

Q How long does a new resident with an out-of-state CDL have to get a NC CDL?

A 30 days after becoming a resident.

Q What check does DMV do for applicants who have lived in NC less than 12 months?

A A search of the National Sex Offender Public Registry (G.S. 20-9(i)). DMV must finish it before issuing a license or ID.

Q What tests might a new resident applying for a Class C license take?

A Knowledge, vision and traffic sign tests. The road test is given if the examiner thinks it's needed.

Q What is a nonresident?

A A person whose legal residence is in another state, territory or country.

Q Give examples of nonresidents.

A Examples include:

- travelers passing through
- out-of-state college students who plan to go home after school
- military members stationed in NC who plan to return home
- spouses of nonresident military members stationed in NC

NC License and ID Card

Q How does DMV take and store photos and signatures?

A With digital imaging. The card also has a bar code that stores customer data.

Q Where are NC licenses and ID cards made, and what do you get at the office?

A They are made at a central location. At the office you get a temporary driving certificate valid for 60 days. Your new license is mailed within 60 days, and you can keep your old card as photo ID until it arrives.

Q How early can you renew a driver license?

A Up to six months before your birthday, or within 180 days before it expires.

Q What kind of license or ID card do drivers under 21 get?

A A vertical card.

Q What color bars appear on cards for applicants under 18?

A Two bars, red and yellow, next to the photo. They show the dates of the 18th and 21st birthdays.

Q What color bar appears on cards for applicants under 21?

A One red bar showing the date they turn 21.

Renewal

Q When does DMV mail a renewal reminder?

A About six months before your license expires.

Q Do you need the reminder card to renew?

A No.

Q What test is required when you renew in person?

A A vision test.

Q What if you don't have your current or expired license when you renew?

A You must show the examiner two identification documents.

Q Who can renew by mail?

A NC residents who have been living outside the state for at least 30 days in a row.

Q When does a renewal-by-mail (temporary) license expire?

A 60 days after you return to NC, or on the expiration date printed on the license, whichever comes first.

Q What are the requirements to renew by mail?

A You must:

- have a permanent NC address that can be verified
- have a Class C license expired no more than two years
- have a photo on file from the last five years
- have your SSN or legal presence on record
- send a vision form signed by a licensed doctor
- sign a National Sex Offender Affidavit
- be no older than 72
- renew this way only every other renewal

Q Which licenses cannot be renewed by mail?

A Commercial licenses and full provisional licenses.

Q What does active-duty military living outside NC need to renew by mail?

A They need:

- a permanent NC address, or a verifiable NC host family's address
- military orders
- a copy of the military ID, front and back
- a Class C license expired no more than two years
- a photo on file from the last eight years

Q Can active-duty military renew more than one year before expiration?

A Yes, if they include military papers showing active-duty status.

Q What other rules apply to military renewal by mail?

A The rules are:

- You need your SSN or legal presence on record.
- You must send a vision form. A vision waiver is allowed for those in a war zone, with documentation.
- You must sign a National Sex Offender Affidavit.
- You must be no older than 72.
- A license with a military designation can be renewed this way no more than two times in your life.
- Military spouses and dependents may also renew by mail.

Q Can a military dependent with a full provisional license upgrade to a Class C?

A Yes, if they are 18, the license has been expired no more than one year, and they meet the issuance requirements.

Q Must a military member visit a license office as soon as they return to NC?

A No. They only need to go in when the license is due for renewal.

Veterans

Q What designation can qualified veterans have on their license or ID?

A "VETERAN."

Q Why did veterans ask for this designation?

A So they can get military discounts by showing their photo ID and veteran status together, without carrying their discharge form.

Q How does a veteran get the designation, and what does it cost?

A Bring a DD-214 (or other proof of honorable discharge) to a license office. It's free at your next renewal. At any other time, you pay the usual duplicate fee.

Q Which documents prove honorable discharge?

A A valid U.S. military ID (DD-2 or DD-214), DD-214, DD-215, WD AGO 53/55, NAVMC 78-PD, or NAVPERS.

Duration, Duplicates, Address & Name Changes

Q How long is a license valid if issued at age 18–65? At 66 or older?

A 8 years for ages 18–65, and 5 years for 66 or older. It expires on your birthday.

Q How do you get a duplicate license?

A Bring your current license (if it isn't expired, suspended or cancelled) to a license office. If it was lost or stolen, show two approved ID documents. You can also do it online if you know your license or ID number.

Q How long do you have to tell DMV about an address change?

A 60 days. You must also get a duplicate license.

Q Do you break the law if your address changes because of a government action, even though you didn't move?

A No.

Q How long do you have to tell DMV about a name change?

A 60 days. You must also get a duplicate license with the new name.

Q What should you do before changing your name with DMV?

A Visit the Social Security Administration office at least 24 hours before. DMV checks your name with the Social Security Online Verification System.

Q Which documents can be used for a name change?

A A certified marriage certificate, court or Register of Deeds proof of the name change, or a notarized DL-101 form.

Identification Cards & Fees

Q Who can get a state ID card?

A Any NC resident. You need the same documents as for a driver license.

Q Who gets a free state ID? What does it cost for someone under 17?

A It's free for residents who are at least 17, legally blind or homeless. It costs $16.75 for someone under 17.

Q What is the yearly fee for a Class A, B or C license?

A $6.50 per year.

Q What is the fee for a motorcycle endorsement?

A $3.05.

Q What is the restoration fee for a non-alcohol offense? For an alcohol offense?

A $83.50 for a non-alcohol offense. $167.25 for an alcohol offense, with $25 going to the Chemical Testing Fund.

Q How much does a learner permit cost?

A $25.50.

Q What are the fees for Level 1, Level 2 and Level 3 graduated licenses?

A $25.50 for Level 1, $25.50 for Level 2, and $6.50 per year for Level 3.

Q How much does a duplicate license cost?

A $16.75.

Q How much is the Driver Improvement Clinic?

A $83.50.

Q How much do copies of driving records cost?

A $12.75 for a limited record (up to 3 years), $12.75 for a complete record, and $18.00 for a certified complete record.

Q How much is a CDL application?

A $51.50.

Q What is the yearly fee for a Class A, B or C CDL?

A $25.50 per year.

Q What are the yearly fees for CDL endorsements?

A H, N, P, S, T and X are $5.00 per year each. M is $3.05 per year.

Q How much is a certified document from DMV? A crash report?

A $16.75 for a certified document, and $6.50 for a crash report.

Other Services

Q Can you register to vote at the DMV?

A Yes. You can register or update your voter registration when you apply for a license, permit or ID.

Q How does a license show that you are an organ donor?

A A heart symbol on the front of the card. It means you agree to be an organ and eye donor.

Q What does the handbook recommend if you choose to be an organ donor?

A Talk with your family so they know your decision. Learn more at DonateLifeNC.org.

Q Who is registered with the Selective Service through a DMV application?

A Male U.S. citizens or immigrants aged 18 to 25 who apply for a license, CDL or ID. Their application counts as consent to register.

Q Where must sex offenders register?

A With the sheriff's office in their county of residence.

Q What happens if an applicant is a registered sex offender in another state?

A DMV won't issue a license, permit or ID until they show proof of registration with the sheriff's office.

Q **What happens if the applicant isn't registered in another state, or the national database is down?**

A The applicant signs an affidavit, and DMV may issue the card.

Chapter 2 — Alcohol and the Law

Q **At what BAC is everyone's driving impaired?**

A 0.08 percent. Many people are affected at much lower levels.

Q **At what BAC does the crash risk start to increase?**

A 0.05 percent. At 0.08 percent, the risk of causing a fatal crash is even higher.

Q **What does BAC stand for?**

A Blood Alcohol Concentration.

Q **What law did North Carolina pass in 1983, and what did it do?**

A The Safe Roads Act. It replaced all earlier drunk-driving laws with one offense: "Driving While Impaired" (DWI).

Q **What happens if you are charged with DWI?**

A You will be asked to take a chemical test of your breath or blood.

Q **What happens if you refuse a chemical test?**

A Your license is revoked right away for at least 30 days. DMV then adds a revocation of at least 12 months.

Q **Can a judge give you a limited driving privilege after a test refusal?**

A In some cases, yes, after six months of the refusal revocation have passed.

Q **What BAC causes an immediate license revocation, and for how long?**

A 0.08 or more, or 0.04 or more in a commercial vehicle. The revocation is at least 30 days.

Q **Can your test result, or your refusal, be used in court?**

A Yes. Both can be used as evidence.

Q **What are the two ways to prove DWI?**

A Either your physical or mental abilities are noticeably impaired by alcohol and/or drugs, or your BAC is 0.08 or more (0.04 or more in a commercial vehicle).

Q **Can police set up roadblocks to check for impaired drivers?**

A Yes.

Q **Can you drink any alcohol, even beer, while driving?**

A No.

Q **Can you have an open container of alcohol in the passenger area of a car?**

A No.

Q **Can you have any alcohol, open or closed, in the passenger area of a commercial vehicle on a public road?**

A No.

Q What is required for someone convicted of DWI a second time?

A A jail sentence.

Q Which DWI offenders must be checked for an alcohol problem?

A Repeat offenders and people with high BACs.

Q What must people with lower BACs attend?

A Alcohol safety school.

Q What must anyone convicted of DWI do before getting their license back?

A Get a substance abuse assessment.

Q What can happen to your vehicle if you are convicted of DWI while your license is revoked for an earlier DWI?

A The court may order it seized and sold.

Q What is the license revocation for a first DWI conviction?

A One year.

Q What is the revocation for a second DWI conviction within three years of a prior offense?

A Four years.

Q What is the revocation for a third DWI conviction?

A Permanent, if at least one earlier conviction was in the past five years.

Q What is the revocation for a fourth DWI conviction?

A Permanent. It is a felony if the three earlier convictions were all in the past seven years.

Q When is a BAC restriction required?

A When a license is restored after a DWI suspension, or when a Limited Driving Privilege is issued after a DWI conviction.

Q What is the BAC restriction on a first restoration? On a second or later restoration?

A 0.04 on the first restoration, and 0.00 on any later one.

Q When is the BAC restriction always 0.00?

A After a DWI in a commercial vehicle, after an under-21 conviction for driving after drinking or using drugs, or after a felony death by vehicle.

Q When is an ignition interlock device required?

A After a DWI conviction with a BAC of 0.15 or more, or after another conviction within the past seven years.

Q What is the legal age to buy alcohol in North Carolina?

A 21.

Q **Which underage alcohol offenses bring a one-year license revocation?**

A Any of these:

- buying or trying to buy alcohol
- helping someone else buy it
- using a fake or borrowed ID to get alcohol
- letting an underage person use your license or ID to buy alcohol
- giving alcohol to an underage person

Q **What happens to a driver under 21 convicted of driving with any amount of alcohol or drugs in their body?**

A A one-year license revocation.

Q **Where can you check for updates to DWI laws?**

A www.ncleg.gov

Chapter 3 — Your Driving Privilege

Points

Q **When are points put on your driving record?**
A When you are convicted of certain traffic violations in North Carolina.

Q **What can happen when you reach 7 points?**
A You may be assigned to a driver improvement clinic, which costs $83.50.

Q **How many points are removed after you complete the clinic?**
A Three.

Q **How many points can lead to a license suspension?**
A 12 points within three years.

Q **How many points after reinstatement can cause a second suspension?**
A 8 points within three years after your license is reinstated.

Q **How long are point-system suspensions?**
A 60 days for the first, 6 months for the second, and 12 months for the third.

Q **What happens to your license points when your license is reinstated?**
A They are all cancelled. Insurance points are not cancelled.

Q How many points are given for each violation (regular vehicle)?

A The points are:

Violation	Points
Passing a stopped school bus	5
Aggressive driving	5
Reckless driving	4
Hit and run (property damage only)	4
Following too closely	4
Driving on the wrong side of the road	4
Illegal passing	4
Failing to yield to a pedestrian (G.S. 20-158(b)(2)b)	4
Failing to yield to a bicycle, motor scooter or motorcycle	4
Running a stop sign	3
Speeding over 55 mph	3
Failing to yield right of way	3
Running a red light	3
No license, or license expired more than one year	3
Failing to stop for a siren	3
Driving through a safety zone	3
No liability insurance	3
Failing to report a crash when required	3
Speeding in a school zone	3
Not properly restraining a child	2
All other moving violations	2
Littering from a motor vehicle	1

Q How many points for passing a stopped school bus?

A 5 (8 in a commercial vehicle).

Q How many points for running a red light or stop sign?

A 3 (4 in a commercial vehicle).

Q How many points for failing to properly restrain a child?

A 2.

Q **How many points are given for each violation in a commercial vehicle?**

A The points are:

Violation	Points
Passing a stopped school bus	8
Rail-highway crossing violation	6
Careless and reckless driving (G.S. 20-140(f))	6
Speeding (G.S. 20-141(j3))	6
Aggressive driving	6
Reckless driving, hit and run (property only), following too closely, wrong side of road, illegal passing, failing to yield to a pedestrian, bicycle, scooter or motorcycle	5 each
Running a stop sign or red light, speeding over 55, failing to yield, no license, failing to stop for a siren, driving through a safety zone, no insurance, failing to report a crash, school zone speeding, having alcohol in the passenger area	4 each
All other moving violations	3
Littering from a motor vehicle	1

Q **Which offenses give NO points?**

A These give no points:

- overload, overlength, overwidth or overheight
- illegal parking
- carrying a concealed weapon
- improper plates or registration
- improper muffler
- improper display of plates or dealer tags
- unlawful display of emblems
- failing to display a current inspection certificate

Q **What extra penalty can apply to point violations in a commercial vehicle?**

A Double the fine or penalty.

Q **Are insurance points the same as driver license points?**

A No. Insurance companies use their own point system. Ask your insurance agent about it.

Suspensions

Q **What gets your license revoked for at least 30 days?**

A Driving more than 15 mph over the speed limit at a speed above 55 mph.

Q What gets your license taken for 60 days?

A Any of these:

- a second conviction within a year for speeding over 55 mph and more than 15 mph over the limit
- speeding plus reckless driving on the same occasion
- two convictions for speeding over 55 within 12 months
- one speeding-over-55 conviction plus one reckless driving conviction within a year
- willful racing, planned or not
- a court sentence ordering you not to drive for a period
- speeding over 75 mph, in some cases

Q When can DMV suspend your license after a conviction?

A As soon as it gets the conviction report from the court.

Q How do you ask for a hearing about a revocation?

A Call 919-715-7000 or click "Contact Us" at NCDMV.gov. DMV mails you the time and place.

Q What can you do if the hearing doesn't help?

A Appeal to the Superior Court in your county within 30 days.

Q How long is the suspension for each serious offense?

A The suspension times are:

Offense	Suspension
Manslaughter	1 year
Death by vehicle	1 year
Manslaughter while impaired	Permanent
Assault with a motor vehicle	1 year
Failing to stop and give aid after a crash	1 year
Speeding over 55 mph and 15+ over the limit while fleeing arrest	1 year
Prearranged racing on the highway	3 years
Watching, betting on or loaning a car for prearranged racing	3 years
Willful refusal of a chemical test	1 year
Two reckless driving charges within 12 months	1 year
Trying to get a license or permit under false pretenses	1 year
Failing to yield (at an intersection, stop or yield sign, when entering a road, for an emergency vehicle, or in a work zone) causing serious injury	90 days and $500

Q What happens to a vehicle used in prearranged racing?

A The officer seizes it. If the person is convicted, the court may order it sold at public auction.

Q What if the court finds that a longer revocation is appropriate?

A DMV must revoke the license for two years.

Q Can out-of-state convictions affect your NC license?

A Yes. They can lead to suspension or revocation as if they happened in NC. DMV must notify you of the date.

Q What happens if you fail to appear in court or don't pay a traffic fine?

A Your license is revoked unless the fine is paid or waived by the date in DMV's letter. The revocation lasts until the court tells DMV it has been paid or waived. You may also have to pay for a duplicate license.

Q Does paying the ticket clear you of the offense itself?

A No. You still face the consequences if you are convicted.

Q What is Option A if you can't afford to pay a fine?

A Four steps:

1. Fill out a Motion for Relief (AOC-CR-415).
2. Give it to the clerk in the county where you got the ticket, and ask for a hearing.
3. Go to the hearing. You don't need a lawyer. The judge may lower the amount, set up a payment plan, or waive it.
4. The court tells DMV, and DMV stops the suspension.

Q Where can you get help filling out the Motion for Relief?

A www.resolvetrafficdebtnc.org

Q What is Option B if you can afford to pay a fine?

A Call the clerk in the county where you got the ticket, then pay the full amount online or in person. The court tells DMV, and DMV stops the suspension.

Provisional Licensee (Under 18) Suspensions

Q How long is a provisional licensee's suspension for a second moving violation within 12 months?

A 30 days.

Q For a third moving violation within 12 months?

A 90 days.

Q For a fourth moving violation within 12 months?

A Six months.

Q **Give examples of moving violations.**

A Examples include:

- passing a stopped school bus
- reckless driving
- hit-and-run
- following too closely
- driving on the wrong side of the road
- illegal passing
- running a stop sign or red light
- failing to yield
- failing to stop for an emergency siren
- speeding

Driver License Restoration

Q **What restoration fee must you pay before a suspension or revocation is cleared?**

A $83.50. It's $167.25 if the revocation came from a DWI.

Q **When is the restoration fee NOT required?**

A When the license was taken for medical or health reasons after a medical evaluation.

Q **What is the extra service fee, and when can you avoid it?**

A $50. You avoid it if you turned your license in to the court or mailed it to DMV before the suspension started.

Q **What are the steps to get your license reinstated?**

A

1. Visit any license office.
2. Prove your identity (your license, or two other acceptable IDs).
3. Pay the restoration and/or service fee.
4. Reapply for a license.
5. Take any required tests.
6. Show proof of insurance if required.
7. Pay for the new license.

Chapter 4 — Your Driving

Driver Safety & Condition

Q When should you not drive?
A When you are too tired or sleepy. You should know your physical and mental limits.

Q What should you do before a long trip?
A Plan ahead, know your route, and watch the driving conditions.

Q How can short-term illnesses like colds, headaches or the flu affect your driving?
A You may be less alert and slower to respond than normal.

Drowsy Driving

Q According to the National Sleep Foundation, what is your number one responsibility as a driver?
A To get yourself and your passengers to your destination safely.

Q How fast does a vehicle at 55 mph cover the length of a football field?
A In 3.7 seconds.

Q Where and when do drowsy-driving crashes happen most?
A On high-speed rural highways, when the driver is alone.

Q Is drowsy driving fully reported?
A No. It is seriously under-reported.

Q What are the warning signs of drowsy driving?
A You can't remember the last few miles, you hit a rumble strip or drift out of your lane, you yawn over and over, or you have trouble focusing or keeping your eyes open.

Q What can help for a short time if you get tired while driving?
A Stop. A short nap of 15 to 45 minutes and some caffeine can help for a while.

Q How often should you stop on long drives?
A At least every 2 hours. Get out, stretch and walk briskly.

Q What is the suggested daily driving limit?
A 300–400 miles.

Q What other tip helps prevent drowsy driving?
A Avoid medications that cause drowsiness, and get a full night's sleep before you drive.

Distracted Driving

Q **What is distracted driving?**

A Any activity that takes your attention away from driving.

Q **Name some common distractions.**

A Texting, using a cell phone, eating and drinking, talking to passengers, grooming, reading (including maps), using a navigation system, watching a video, and adjusting the radio or music player.

Q **How do distractions affect drivers?**

A Distracted drivers:

- react more slowly
- miss hazards like pedestrians or debris more often
- have a harder time avoiding crashes, because many distractions take a hand off the wheel

Q **Is it legal to text or email while driving in North Carolina?**

A No. It's illegal on any public street, highway or public vehicular area.

Q **Can drivers under 18 use a cell phone while the vehicle is moving?**

A No. The exception is calling 911 in an emergency.

Q **Can a school bus driver use a cell phone while driving?**

A No.

Q **What cell phone safety tips does the handbook give?**

A The tips are:

- Use the phone only when absolutely needed, such as an emergency or to contact a parent, guardian or spouse.
- Use it at a safe time and place.
- Have a passenger make the call.
- Don't feel you have to answer.
- Secure the phone so it doesn't fly around in a crash.

Medications & Alcohol

Q **How should you handle medications before driving?**

A Find out how the medication affects you. Drive as little as possible while taking it, and be extra careful if you must drive.

Q **What percent of traffic deaths involve alcohol?**

A About 38 percent.

Q **What kind of drug is alcohol?**

A A depressant.

Q How does alcohol affect driving?

A Alcohol:

- slows your brain, decisions and reactions
- hurts your judgment of speed and distance
- gives you false confidence
- makes it harder to do more than one thing at a time
- affects your balance (very important on a motorcycle)
- makes you sleepy

Q What is the only thing that sobers a person up?

A Time. Coffee, a big meal or a cold shower won't work.

Q What are some alternatives to drinking and driving?

A Plan other transportation, share a taxi, take public transit, stay overnight with a friend, ride with a driver who hasn't been drinking, or get a ride from a friend or relative.

Seat Belts

Q What are your lifetime odds of being seriously injured or killed in a crash?

A About one in three.

Q Who must wear a seat belt?

A The driver and all passengers, any time the vehicle is moving forward on a street or highway. Children under 16 should be in a restraint that fits their age and weight.

Q Must you wear a seat belt if the car has air bags?

A Yes.

Q If the vehicle has automatic shoulder harnesses, must you wear the lap belt too?

A Yes.

Q Who is exempt from the seat belt law?

A Exemptions include:

- people in a noncommercial vehicle with a medical or physical condition that prevents belt use, or a professionally certified phobia of restraints
- rural USPS letter carriers and newspaper carriers on their routes
- drivers or passengers who make frequent delivery stops at no more than 20 mph between stops
- property-carrying vehicles used for farming within the state
- vehicles not required by law to have seat belts
- motor home occupants other than the driver and front passengers, if the motor home has at least four living facilities
- when all seats with belts or child restraints are already taken

Q What living facilities count toward the motor home exemption?

A Cooking, a refrigerator or icebox, a self-contained toilet, heating or air conditioning, a water system with a faucet and sink, a separate 110–115 volt power supply, and LP gas.

Child Safety

Q What is the number one threat to the lives of young children?

A Car crashes.

Q How many children killed while unrestrained could properly used safety seats save?

A Seven out of every ten.

Q What is the "best" child safety seat?

A One that is used every time the child rides. It fits your car, has a comfortable harness or shield, and is a seat you are able and willing to use every time.

Q Where can you find low-cost safety seat rentals?

A From local service groups, hospitals and health departments.

Q Who must be properly secured when you have passengers under 16?

A Every passenger under 16, in a child restraint or seat belt that meets federal standards.

Q Which children must be in a weight-appropriate child restraint system?

A Children under 8 who weigh less than 80 pounds.

Q When must a child sit in the rear seat?

A When the car has an active passenger-side front air bag and a rear seat, a child under 5 who weighs less than 40 pounds must ride in back. The exception is a restraint designed to be used with a front air bag.

Q When can a child under 8, weighing 40–80 pounds, use just a lap belt?

A When no seat with a lap and shoulder belt is available to properly secure the child restraint.

Q Who can you contact for child safety seat information?

A The UNC Highway Safety Research Center, at info@buckleupnc.org.

Q When should a child use a booster seat?

A After outgrowing their standard safety seat, until they are big enough for the adult seat belt to fit correctly.

Q How should a seat belt fit a child?

A The lap belt goes snug across the hips, not the stomach. The shoulder belt goes across the shoulder and chest, not the face or throat.

Air Bags

Q How fast does an air bag come out?

A Up to 200 mph, faster than the blink of an eye.

Q When do air bags work best?

A When everyone is buckled up and children are properly restrained in the back seat.

Q **Where should children 12 and under ride?**

A Buckled up in a rear seat.

Q **Can an infant in a rear-facing seat ride in the front seat with a passenger air bag?**

A NEVER.

Q **Are air bags a replacement for seat belts?**

A No. They are supplemental (extra) protection. Use both lap and shoulder belts on every trip.

Q **How should an adult wear a seat belt?**

A The lap belt goes under the abdomen and low across the hips. The shoulder belt goes over the collarbone, away from the neck, and across the breastbone.

Q **How far forward should the driver and front passenger seats be?**

A As far back as practical, especially for shorter people.

Motorcycle Helmet Law

Q **Who must wear a helmet on a motorcycle or moped?**

A All riders and passengers. The helmet must meet FMVSS 218.

Q **What are the three signs of a legal helmet?**

A

1. A thick inner liner of firm polystyrene foam, about one inch thick.
2. A "DOT" symbol put on the back permanently by the manufacturer.
3. A permanent manufacturer's label inside, showing the maker, model, size, month and year made, materials, and care instructions.

Q **Does sticking on a separately bought DOT sticker make a helmet legal?**

A No.

Pick-up Trucks

Q **Can children under 16 ride in the open bed of a pick-up truck?**

A No (NCGS §20-135.2B), with some exceptions.

Q **What is an "open bed"?**

A A bed or cargo area with no permanent overhead structure to hold riders in.

Q **Who is responsible for following the pick-up truck law?**

A The driver.

Q What are the exceptions to the pick-up truck law?

A The law does not apply:

- when an adult is in the bed supervising the child
- when the child is secured with an approved seat belt (FMVSS 208, rated at least 5,000 lbs)
- in an emergency
- in a parade
- in farming work, including trips to and from the main place of the business

Q What is the penalty for breaking the pick-up truck law?

A A $25 fine. It is an infraction, with no court costs, license points or insurance surcharges.

Weather Risk

Q How much hotter can it get inside a parked car than outside?

A About 40–50 degrees hotter.

Q What can happen to children or animals left in a hot car?

A Dehydration, heat stroke and death.

Q What winter danger can come from warming up a car?

A Snow can block the exhaust pipe. Carbon monoxide can then back up into the car.

Q What is carbon monoxide?

A An invisible gas with no smell, taste or color. It is poisonous and can kill.

Pedestrians

Q Do pedestrians have the right of way at intersections without traffic signals?

A Yes, if they are in a marked crosswalk or an unmarked one. An unmarked crosswalk is the imaginary extension of the sidewalk across the street.

Q What signals do pedestrians obey at intersections with regular traffic lights?

A The same signals as drivers going the same direction. They shouldn't start crossing on red or yellow.

Q Who has the right of way when a pedestrian crosses on a green light?

A The pedestrian, over all vehicles, including turning vehicles.

Q What must you do if the light changes while a pedestrian is still in the street?

A Let them finish crossing safely.

Q Which pedestrians get special consideration at intersections without signals?

A Blind pedestrians who hold out a white cane (or a white cane with a red tip), or who have a guide dog.

Q When "Walk/Don't Walk" signals are working, which signal do pedestrians follow?

A The pedestrian signal, not the regular traffic light. They have the right of way when crossing with it.

Q What should you do if a pedestrian starts crossing against a red light in front of you?

A Warn them with your horn.

Q When does the law require you to use your horn for pedestrians?

A When a pedestrian may be affected by your turn, stop or start from a parked position. If the pedestrian doesn't stop, you must.

Q Should you yield to a pedestrian who doesn't have the right of way?

A Yes. A safe driver yields to pedestrians either way. Saving a life is worth more than your right of way.

Motorcyclists

Q What happens if a driver fails to signal and forces a motorcycle to change lanes or leave the road?

A The driver is charged and fined. Bigger penalties apply if it causes property damage or injury.

School Buses

Q What is the maximum speed limit for a school bus?

A 45 mph.

Q When are school buses usually on the road?

A Generally 7–9 a.m. and 2–4 p.m.

Q About how many miles do NC school buses travel, and how many children do they carry each school day?

A More than half a million miles, carrying almost three quarters of a million children.

Q When a school bus shows its stop arm or flashing red lights, when may you go again?

A Only after the stop arm is pulled back, the red lights are off, and the bus has started moving.

Q Who must stop for a stopped school bus on a two-lane road?

A All traffic in both directions.

Q On a two-lane road with a center turn lane?

A All traffic in both directions.

Q On a four-lane road with no median?

A All traffic in both directions.

Q On a divided highway of four or more lanes with a median?

A Only traffic behind the bus.

Q On a road of four or more lanes with a center turn lane?

A Only traffic behind the bus.

Emergency Vehicles

Q **Which vehicles always have the right of way when using flashing lights and sirens?**

A Police cars, ambulances, fire engines and rescue vehicles.

Q **What should you do when an emergency vehicle comes toward you from ahead or behind?**

A Pull to the right curb or edge of the road and stop completely. Stay stopped until it passes or an officer tells you to move.

Q **How close can you park to an emergency vehicle stopped at a crash?**

A No closer than 100 feet.

Q **When do you NOT have to yield to an emergency vehicle?**

A When you are going the opposite way on a four-lane limited-access highway with a center median.

Q **How close can you drive or park to a fire truck answering an alarm?**

A No closer than one block.

Q **Can you drive over a fire hose?**

A Never.

Q **What does the Move Over law require on a road with two or more lanes in your direction?**

A When an emergency or service vehicle is stopped within 12 feet of the road with its lights on, move out of the lane closest to it. Stay in your new lane until you're safely past.

Q **What does the Move Over law require on a road with only one lane in your direction?**

A Slow down to a safe speed until you're completely past.

Q **Which vehicles does the Move Over law cover?**

A Police, fire, ambulance and rescue vehicles, plus public service vehicles helping with wrecked or disabled vehicles.

Being Stopped by Law Enforcement

Q **What should you do when you see emergency lights or hear a siren behind you?**

A Stay calm, turn on your signal, and pull to the right, off the road, at the nearest safe spot.

Q **What if there is no safe place to stop right away?**

A Turn on your four-way flashers and slow down by about 10 mph to show the officer you see them. Keep driving legally until you reach a safe spot.

Q **What can you do if you're unsure an unmarked car is really the police?**

A Call 911 before you pull over. Give your name and location so they can confirm it's a real officer.

Q **What should you do after you stop?**

A Put the car in Park, roll down the window, turn off the engine, and silence your devices and radio. Stay seated. Keep your seat belt on unless the officer asks you to take it off.

Q **Where should you and your passengers keep your hands?**

A Yours go on the steering wheel. Passengers keep theirs where the officer can see them. Back-seat passengers put their hands on the back of the front seat.

Q **What should you do at night when stopped?**

A Turn on your interior lights.

Q **What are you required by law to give the officer?**

A Your identity, your driver license and the vehicle registration. After that, you can choose whether to answer more questions.

Q **What if the officer isn't in uniform?**

A They will show their credentials, or you can ask to see them.

Q **What are the rules about weapons during a traffic stop?**

A Don't reach for any weapon. Weapons must be in plain view or locked away unless you have a permit. If you or a passenger has a concealed carry permit and a weapon is in the car, you must tell the officer.

Q **Can you or your passengers get out of the car?**

A Only if the officer tells you to.

Q **Should you search the glove box or under the seat for your license or registration?**

A Not unless the officer asks. Avoid sudden movements.

Q **Can you talk on your phone during the stop?**

A No. The officer will tell you whether you can answer a call.

Q **What if you don't understand an instruction?**

A Calmly tell the officer and ask them to repeat or explain it.

Q **What should you do if you disagree with a ticket?**

A Don't argue with the officer.

Q **Does accepting and signing a traffic ticket mean you admit guilt?**

A No. You can contest it in court.

Q **What kind of crime is resisting, delaying or obstructing an officer during a traffic stop?**

A A Class 2 misdemeanor (N.C.G.S. §14-223).

Q **What should you do if you think an officer acted inappropriately?**

A Write down what happened, and report it to the officer's agency soon. The officer's name and agency are on the ticket.

Q **How does an officer start a traffic stop?**

A By turning on blue lights and/or a siren.

Q What will the officer do when they come to your car?

A Identify themselves and their agency, explain why they stopped you, and ask for your license and registration.

Farm Equipment

Q When do most crashes with farm equipment happen?

A On clear days, in daylight, on dry paved roads.

Q What types of crashes are most common with farm equipment?

A Sideswipes and angle crashes. They usually happen when the farm equipment turns left and another vehicle tries to pass.

Q Why might a driver wrongly try to pass farm equipment?

A The operator may use a left-hand signal, which the driver mistakes as a sign to pass.

Q Can you pass farm equipment in a no-passing zone?

A No. It is illegal and very dangerous.

Q What is the key to safety around farm equipment?

A Patience. The only advisable time to pass is when the operator moves off the road to let traffic go by.

Q What lights must farm equipment have?

A One white light in front and one red light in back, visible for up to 500 feet. Two red reflectors at least 4 inches across can replace the rear light.

Q Why should you approach farm equipment with extra care?

A Because it moves slowly, you close the distance much faster than you expect.

Q Where is farm equipment not allowed?

A On interstates. It may legally use most other NC roads.

Funeral Processions

Q What lights must vehicles in a funeral procession use?

A Headlights on, plus hazard warning lights if the vehicle has them.

Q When can the rest of a funeral procession go through an intersection without stopping?

A When the lead vehicle has gone through legally, when an officer or funeral director directs it, or when a police vehicle is leading it.

Q Must you yield to a funeral procession coming the opposite way?

A You may. If you do, slow down or stop fully off the road so other traffic can keep moving in its lane.

Q Can you pass a funeral procession going your direction?

A Only if the highway has two or more marked lanes in that direction.

Q **Can you drive between vehicles in a funeral procession?**

A Not knowingly. Don't enter an intersection while the procession goes through a red light, even if your light is green, unless you can do it safely without crossing its path.

Your Side of the Road & Speed

Q **Which side of the road must you drive on?**

A The right side. Driving on the left is legal only in some cases, such as on one-way streets or while passing.

Q **Which lane should you use on a multi-lane highway if you're going slower than the speed limit?**

A The far right lane, unless you are passing, turning left or avoiding something in the road.

Q **What two things decide your stopping distance?**

A Your speed and your reaction time.

Q **About how far does it take to stop at 55 mph in ideal conditions?**

A About 211 feet.

Q **Why is driving well below the speed limit dangerous?**

A Slow drivers force others to creep behind them or pass in risky ways. Very slow cars are especially dangerous just past a hill or curve. Studies show that very slow vehicles are much more likely to be in crashes.

Q **What should you do if traffic builds up behind you?**

A Pull over, stop, and let the vehicles pass.

Q **What are the most important speed rules?**

A Never go faster than the posted limit or faster than conditions allow. Keep a two-second following distance. The faster you go, the farther ahead you must be able to see.

Q **What is the speed limit in cities and towns unless posted otherwise?**

A 35 mph.

Q **What are the maximum speed limits in North Carolina?**

A The limits are:

Area or vehicle	Limit
Cities and towns	35 mph
School buses	45 mph
School activity buses	55 mph
Outside cities and towns	55 mph
Interstates	70 mph

Curves & Turning

Q What is the best way to handle a curve?

A
1. Slow down before you enter the curve.
2. Speed up slowly through the curve to keep traction.
3. If you must brake in the curve, brake gently.
4. Start turning just before the road turns.
5. Stay on your side, as far right as you can.

Q How do you handle a curve while going downhill?

A Remember the pull of gravity. Shift to a lower gear before going downhill. Brake earlier and approach the curve more slowly than on flat ground.

Q How should you make a right turn?

A Stay close to the right edge so no one can get between you and the curb. Slow down before the turn, then speed up slightly.

Q Which vehicles are hardest to see when you turn?

A Motorcycles and bicycles.

Following & Changing Lanes

Q What is a leading cause of traffic crashes?

A Following too closely.

Q What is the two-second rule?

A Leave at least two seconds between when the car ahead passes a point and when you reach the same point.

Q On the open road, how much room should you leave ahead of you?

A Enough for a passing vehicle to safely move into the space.

Q On a multi-lane highway, which lanes should you check when changing lanes?

A The lane you're moving into and the lane beyond it.

Q What are the steps for changing lanes?

A Check your side and rear-view mirrors, look over your shoulder at your blind spot, signal ahead of time, then change lanes.

Passing

Q What are the steps for passing?

A Look ahead and behind to make sure it's safe, signal, then tap the horn to alert the driver ahead.

Q What does honking when you pass legally require of the other driver?

A The driver being passed must help you pass.

Q How far to the left must you be when passing another vehicle?

A At least two feet.

Q How do you know you did NOT pass safely?

A The vehicle you passed had to slow down to let you back into your lane.

Q Where is passing always unsafe and usually illegal?

A In these places:

- at intersections in cities and towns, or at railroad crossings
- at marked intersections in rural areas
- on curves or hills where you can't see at least 500 feet ahead
- where there's a solid yellow line in your lane
- where there's a double solid yellow line
- where a vehicle has stopped at an intersection or crosswalk to let people cross
- anywhere you can't see that the road is clear far enough ahead

Q Is passing on the right legal?

A Usually not. It puts you in the other driver's blind spot.

Q When is passing on the right allowed?

A On highways with at least two lanes in each direction, on one-way streets, when passing a car in a left-turn lane, and when driving in a right-turn lane.

Q How do you pass on a three-lane highway?

A Only in the center lane, and only where it is marked for passing in your direction. The exception is when the car in the center lane is turning left.

Q What must you do when someone is passing you?

A Help them pass. If they honk, move to the right edge. Never speed up.

Q What is the penalty if you speed up while being passed and it causes a crash?

A A misdemeanor charge, if the crash causes injury or property damage.

Backing & Parking

Q What should you check before getting in to back up?

A Look behind the vehicle for small objects or children.

Q How should you steer and look when backing?

A Steer with your left hand and look over your right shoulder through the back window. Don't rely only on mirrors or the side window.

Q How fast should you back up?

A Very slowly, no more than 10 mph.

Q Which side of the road should you park on?

A The right side, except on one-way streets.

Q What should you do before pulling out of a parallel parking space?

A Check for traffic and give a left-turn signal (unless you're parked on the left side of a one-way street).

Q What should you do if a car ahead is pulling out of a parallel parking space?

A Slow down and be ready to stop.

Q Where should you not park?

A In these places:

- at an intersection or in front of a driveway
- within 25 feet of the curb line of a cross street (15 feet if there's no curb)
- on a crosswalk, sidewalk or bridge
- within 15 feet of a fire hydrant or fire station entrance
- on the paved part of a highway (or on the shoulder unless you're visible from 200 feet both ways)
- double-parked
- where "No Parking" signs are posted
- within one block of a fire or fire truck in a city (400 feet outside a city)
- anywhere on an interstate right of way, except designated areas or emergencies
- in handicap spaces without a plate or placard

Q How close can you park to a fire hydrant?

A No closer than 15 feet.

Q How close can you park to an intersection?

A No closer than 25 feet from the curb line, or 15 feet from the right-of-way lines if there's no curb.

Q When can you park on a highway shoulder?

A Only if drivers coming from both directions can see your vehicle from at least 200 feet away.

Q Where can you learn more about the Americans with Disabilities Act?

A www.ada.gov

Intersections & Right of Way

Q What is an interchange, and what should you do when you approach one?

A An intersection where roads cross at different levels. Slow down and follow the signs that tell you how to turn.

Q What is an intersection?

A Any place where two or more roads meet or cross.

Q Where do most crashes happen?

A At intersections. They are the most dangerous places on a street or highway.

Q What share of fatal crashes happen at intersections?

A More than one-third.

Q When is each crossing of a four-lane divided highway a separate intersection?

A When the median is more than 30 feet wide.

Q Must you slow down at an intersection even if you have the right of way?

A Yes. The law requires it.

Q At an intersection with no signs or signals, who has the right of way?

A The vehicle already in the intersection.

Q If two vehicles reach an uncontrolled intersection at the same time, who goes first?

A The vehicle on the right.

Q If two facing vehicles arrive at the same time and one wants to turn left, who has the right of way?

A The vehicle going straight. The left-turning driver must signal and wait.

Q Can you change lanes while driving through an intersection?

A Never.

Q What must you do at a stop sign?

A Come to a complete stop and yield to traffic on the through street.

Q What must you do when leaving a private driveway?

A Stop and yield to all vehicles and pedestrians.

Q What should you do at an unmarked intersection where it's hard to see?

A Stop, then move forward slowly and carefully.

Q What is a single-point interchange?

A Two intersections combined into one, over or under a free-flowing road. One set of traffic signals controls through traffic and left turns.

Traffic Circles & Roundabouts

Q Which direction do vehicles travel in a traffic circle or roundabout?

A Counterclockwise (to the right).

Q How do you leave a traffic circle?

A By turning right. In a circle with more than one lane, get into the outside lane before your exit.

Q Can you make a right turn from an inside lane of a circle?

A Never.

Q Who has the right of way in a traffic circle?

A Vehicles already in the circle.

Q **Is a traffic circle one intersection or several?**

A The whole circle is one intersection.

Q **Why is NCDOT building more roundabouts?**

A To improve safety for drivers, pedestrians and bicyclists, and to reduce congestion and backups.

Q **What speed do modern roundabouts require?**

A 15–20 mph.

Q **What happened to crashes after roundabouts replaced traditional intersections in NC?**

A Total crashes, fatal and injury crashes, and head-on crashes all went down.

Q **What sign warns you that a roundabout is ahead?**

A A yellow "Roundabout Ahead" sign. Slow down when you see it.

Q **Who must yield when entering a roundabout?**

A Drivers entering must yield to vehicles and bicyclists already in it. Those inside don't yield to drivers coming in.

Q **What should you do when leaving a roundabout?**

A Use your turn signal and yield to pedestrians in the crosswalk.

Q **In a single-lane roundabout, how far around do you go to turn right, go straight, turn left, or make a U-turn?**

A A quarter of the way to turn right, halfway to go straight, three-quarters to turn left, and all the way around for a U-turn.

Q **In a multi-lane roundabout, which lane do you use?**

A The right lane to exit right. The left lane to go straight, turn left or make a U-turn. Choose your lane before you enter, and don't change lanes inside.

Q **What is the truck apron?**

A A concrete island that big trucks use to get around the roundabout. Give trucks and buses extra room.

Q **What should you do if an emergency vehicle comes through a roundabout?**

A Never enter while it's passing. If you're already inside, exit first, then pull over.

Q **How should bicyclists ride in a roundabout?**

A Choose a lane before entering, ride in the middle of it, and stay off the shoulder. Drivers must not pass a bicyclist inside the roundabout.

Q **Where should pedestrians cross at a roundabout?**

A In the marked crosswalks around the outside, never through the middle.

Railroad Crossings

Q How far from the nearest rail must you stop at a railroad crossing?

A Within 50 feet, but no closer than 15 feet.

Q When must you stop at a railroad crossing?

A When:

- a signal warns that a train is coming
- the gate is down or a flagger signals
- a train within about 1,500 feet sounds a signal and is an immediate hazard
- a train is plainly visible and dangerously close

Q Can you drive around or under a lowered crossing gate?

A No. You also can't when it is opening or closing. The same goes for pedestrians.

Q Where should you stop when waiting at a railroad crossing?

A As far right as possible. Don't form two lanes unless the road has four or more marked lanes.

Q What kind of offense is breaking the railroad signal law?

A An infraction.

Q What happens to an employer who lets a commercial driver break the railroad crossing law?

A It is an infraction, plus a civil penalty.

Q How many miles of railroad track and how many crossings are in North Carolina?

A Over 5,000 miles of track and 6,800 crossings.

Q How far does a train going 55 mph need to stop?

A More than a mile.

Q What does a round yellow and black "RR" sign mean?

A A railroad crossing is ahead.

Q Who has the right of way at a railroad crossing?

A The train always does, even over police, fire and ambulance vehicles.

Q What should you do at a railroad crossing sign?

A Approach with caution, be ready to stop, and go carefully once the train has passed. Never stop on the tracks.

Q What is a crossbuck?

A The X-shaped sign at a railroad crossing. A smaller sign below it shows if there is more than one track.

Q What should you do as you approach a railroad crossing?

A Slow down, look both ways, listen for a train, stay alert, and watch for the signal.

Q **Must you yield to a train at a crossing with only a crossbuck and no lights or gates?**

A Yes, always.

Q **What do you do at flashing red lights with a crossbuck?**

A Stop, just as you would at any flashing red signal.

Q **Why shouldn't you go right after a train passes?**

A Another train may be coming from the other direction or following the first one. Wait until the red lights stop flashing.

Q **Which vehicles must stop at railroad crossings?**

A School buses, passenger vehicles, for-hire vehicles, and vehicles carrying explosives or hazardous materials. Be ready to stop behind them.

Q **What should you do if the lights start flashing or the gates start coming down while you're on the tracks?**

A Don't stop and don't back up. KEEP MOVING. The signals give you enough time to get across.

Q **Can you drive on railroad tracks anywhere other than a crossing?**

A No. Railroads are private property.

Q **What if the gate on the far side of the tracks comes down before you get across?**

A Don't panic. Crossing gates can't trap you. Drive through the gate, because it is flexible. If you stop and try to back up, your car may stall.

Q **What CAN trap you on the tracks?**

A Stopped traffic. Make sure traffic ahead won't stop and block you on the tracks.

Q **What is the "Blue Sign"?**

A The Railroad Emergency Notification System (ENS) sign. It shows the crossing ID number, the railroad company's name and an emergency phone number. Using it is the fastest way to get a train stopped in an emergency.

Q **Must every NC railroad crossing have a Blue Sign?**

A Yes, one in each traffic direction.

Q **Does every crossing have its own ID number?**

A Yes. Each crossing has a unique USDOT crossing ID number, and each railroad has its own emergency number.

Q **What should you do if your vehicle stalls on or near the tracks?**

A GET OUT IMMEDIATELY. Walk quickly away from the car and the tracks. Once you're safe, call the number on the Blue Sign.

Q **Who do you call about damaged or missing Blue Signs?**

A The USDOT Federal Railroad Administration at 1-800-232-0144.

Q What is a train hitting a 4,000-lb car compared to?

A Your car running over a soda can.

Bicycle Lanes, City, Open & Secondary Roads

Q What crash risk do bike lanes create at intersections?

A A crash between a bicyclist going straight and a driver turning right.

Q What should you do if you're in the wrong lane for a turn in the city?

A Go on to the next intersection and turn there.

Q How do you know you're probably in another driver's blind spot?

A When you can't see the inside rear-view mirror of the car ahead.

Q What are the rules for city driving?

A The rules are:

- Leave a margin of safety around your car.
- Signal your moves.
- Look far ahead.
- Don't drive side-by-side, especially in blind spots.
- Never weave between lanes.
- Signal before changing lanes.
- Be ready to brake.
- Watch for parked cars pulling out and pedestrians stepping out between cars.

Q On a one-way street, which lanes do you use for going straight and for turning?

A Center lanes for going straight. Outside lanes for turning.

Q Why are rural roads often more dangerous than city traffic?

A Roads may be narrower, lighting may be worse, and speeds may be higher. Also watch for slow drivers and wildlife.

Q How are secondary roads different from primary roads?

A They're built for local travel. Hills are steeper, curves are sharper and sight distances are short. They can't safely be driven at primary-highway speeds.

Interstate Highways

Q Why are interstates safer?

A They have:

- separate lanes for each direction
- fewer entrances and exits
- no railroad crossings, sharp curves, stop signs or traffic signals

Q How do you contact NC Quick Pass about toll roads?

A Call 1-877-769-7277 or visit www.myncquickpass.com.

Q What should you check before an interstate trip?

A Water, oil, tires and gas.

Q How do you enter an interstate?

A Use the acceleration lane until you match the speed of traffic, then merge safely.

Q Which lane should you use on the interstate?

A Keep right. Use the left lane(s) only for passing.

Q What is one of the most common interstate crashes?

A Rear-end crashes. Don't tailgate, and use the two-second rule.

Q How often should you stop at rest areas?

A At least once every 100 miles.

Q What should you do if your car breaks down on the interstate?

A Pull far off the road. Tie a white cloth to the antenna or left door handle and raise the hood. At night, turn on your flashers or parking lights.

Q What should you do if you see a broken-down vehicle?

A Contact the NC State Highway Patrol or local police right away.

Q How do you exit the interstate?

A Signal well in advance. Move into the deceleration lane without slowing down first, then follow the posted exit speed.

Q What are some general highway driving tips?

A The tips are:

- Look farther ahead as your speed goes up.
- Watch for hidden intersections and driveways, warning signs, and oversized or slow vehicles.
- Use headlights when visibility is poor.
- Watch for drivers passing in oncoming lines of traffic.
- Always have an escape route.

Q Is driving far below the speed limit on an interstate dangerous?

A Yes. Crashes are more likely when a vehicle is much slower than traffic. Go with the flow without speeding.

Q What should you do if you enter an interstate going the wrong way?

A Pull onto the right shoulder and stop. When it's clear, turn around. Watch for DO NOT ENTER signs to avoid this.

Q What should you do if you miss your exit?

A Don't slow down, back up or turn around. Go on to the next exit.

Vehicle Equipment

Q How far should you see with high beams? With low beams?

A About 200 feet with high beams and 75 feet with low beams.

Q What can knock headlights out of adjustment?

A Vehicle vibration. Overloading the rear of the car can also tilt the headlights up and cause glare.

Q What color must taillights be, and how far must they be visible?

A Red, visible for at least 500 feet.

Q What does the law require for your license plate light?

A A white light that makes the plate readable from at least 50 feet.

Q What brake and turn lights must vehicles made since 1955 have?

A Red or amber lights that come on with braking or signaling, visible for at least 100 feet in daylight.

Q How should your mirrors be adjusted?

A The rear-view mirror shows directly behind you. The side mirrors show the left and right rear, barely showing the side of your car.

Q How many separate ways to apply the brakes should a vehicle have?

A Two.

Q How far from the floor should the brake pedal be when fully pressed?

A At least one-third of its original distance. If it isn't, get the brakes checked.

Q What does it mean if the brake pedal slowly sinks under your foot?

A The hydraulic system needs to be checked.

Q What should you do about squeaky brakes?

A Have them checked.

Q What three things does ABS improve?

A Stability (avoiding spin-outs), steerability, and stopping ability.

Q How do you brake with ABS?

A Brake hard with firm, steady pressure. Don't pump the brakes.

Q How can you help prevent auto theft?

A Never leave the key in the ignition of an unattended vehicle.

Q When is a tire unsafe?

A When it is cut, cracked or worn down to the cord. Also when it shows tread separation or chunking, or has less than 1/16 inch of tread.

Q What happens with under-inflated or over-inflated tires?

A Under-inflated tires wear out faster and are more likely to blow out. Over-inflated tires lose traction and wear in the middle.

Q How often should you check tire pressure, and when?

A At least once a month, when the tires are cool.

Q Who may have emergency lights or sirens?

A Only law enforcement and emergency vehicles.

Q How far away must your horn be heard?

A At least 200 feet. It must not make an unreasonably loud or harsh sound.

Q What does the muffler do?

A It filters smoke and excess noise.

Q Why is an exhaust leak dangerous?

A Carbon monoxide can get into the car. It can make you sleepy or unconscious, and it can kill.

Q How far is it suggested you keep a window open while driving?

A About one inch.

Q What are signs of a bad suspension?

A The car sways freely, leans heavily in turns, or keeps bouncing.

Q What are emergency flashers used for?

A To warn others of danger, or that your vehicle is stopped or disabled. They flash all four turn signals.

Drive Green

Q How much can every 5 mph over 60 cost you?

A Up to 30 cents more per gallon.

Q How much can quick starts and hard stops increase fuel use?

A By 40%.

Q When should you use the windows versus the AC?

A Roll the windows down under 40 mph. Use the AC over 40 mph.

Q How much fuel can cruise control save?

A About 60 gallons a year, if you drive more than 10,000 miles a year.

Q How much can a clogged air filter cut your mileage?

A 10%.

Q How much gas can a loose fuel cap waste?

A Up to 30 gallons a year.

Q When should you turn off the engine while waiting?

A If you'll be waiting more than a couple of minutes.

Defensive Driving

Q What two types of driving skills are there?

A Defensive skills to avoid crashes despite other drivers' mistakes, and basic skills for turning, passing, backing and parking.

Q How far ahead should you look?

A 10 to 15 seconds ahead, about one city block.

Q How often should you check your mirrors?

A About every 10 seconds.

Q What are blind spots?

A Areas near the left and right rear corners of the vehicle that you can't see in your mirrors. Turn your head to check them before changing lanes or turning.

Q What else can create blind spots?

A Glaring lights, dirty windshields, cars parked too close to intersections, bushes and buildings.

Q When should you signal?

A Every time you slow down, stop, turn, change lanes or pull away from the curb, even if you see no one. Make sure the move is safe first.

Q What is the hand signal for a left turn?

A Arm and hand straight out, pointing with the first finger.

Q What is the hand signal for a right turn?

A Arm out with the forearm and hand straight up, palm facing forward.

Q What is the hand signal for stopping or slowing down?

A Arm and hand pointing down, palm facing back.

Q When are flashing turn signals hard to see?

A In late afternoon and early morning, when the lenses reflect sunlight.

Q How far before a turn or stop must you signal?

A At least the last 100 feet. If the speed limit is 45 mph or more, at least the last 200 feet.

Q What should you do if someone is following you too closely?

A Move to another lane and signal for them to pass.

Q What is the key to successful driving?

A Adjusting to road conditions, including knowing when it's too dangerous to drive at all.

Q How do you handle two dangers at once?

A Give the most room to the biggest or most likely danger. For example, give a child on a bike more room than oncoming cars. If the dangers are equal, stop and let the oncoming traffic pass.

Work Zones

Q Where does a highway work zone begin and end?

A From the first sign marking the start to the last sign marking the end.

Q What extra penalty can apply for speeding in a work zone?

A An extra penalty, if a sign at the start of the work zone lists it. It's added to the normal speeding penalty.

Q What color are work zone signs?

A Black letters on orange.

Q What does the "Flagger" sign mean?

A A flagger in an orange vest is ahead, using a STOP/SLOW paddle. Stay alert and be ready to stop.

Q What is a major cause of rear-end crashes in work zones?

A Driving slower than the surrounding traffic.

Q Name some traffic control devices used in work zones.

A Barricades, cones, drums and flaggers.

Night Driving

Q When must you use headlights?

A From sunset to sunrise, when you can see 400 feet or less, and whenever your wipers are on because of bad weather.

Q When should you use high beams versus low beams at night?

A Low beams in the city. High beams on the open road, unless you're approaching or following another vehicle.

Q Why is night driving more dangerous?

A You can't see as well, there are more impaired and tired drivers, oncoming headlights can blind you, and dirty windshields and bad lights cause problems.

Q What should you do if an oncoming driver doesn't dim their high beams?

A Flash your high beams once. If they still don't dim, keep yours on low.

Q Where should you look to avoid oncoming headlights?

A Slightly to the right, using the edge of the road as a guide.

Q What speed rule applies at night?

A Never drive faster than you can stop within the distance you can see.

Q What should you do when parking along a highway at night?

A Turn on your emergency flashers. Never leave your headlights on, because they can blind oncoming drivers.

Sun Glare, Rain & Hydroplaning

Q How do you deal with sun glare?

A Use your sun visor and sunglasses. If that doesn't help, pull off and wait until you can drive safely.

Q How much longer is stopping distance on slippery pavement?

A Two to 10 times longer than on dry pavement.

Q What following distance should you use in the rain?

A At least twice the normal distance.

Q When are roads most dangerous during rain?

A In the first 10 to 15 minutes, especially after a dry spell. Rain mixes with oil, dirt, dust and rubber to make a slick surface.

Q How much slower should you drive on wet pavement?

A At least 5 to 10 mph slower than on dry pavement.

Q What is hydroplaning?

A When a thin sheet of water gets between your tires and the road, so the tires lose contact.

Q At what speed and water depth can hydroplaning start?

A As low as 30 mph, in water just over 1/8 inch deep.

Q What should you do if you start to hydroplane?

A Take your foot off the gas. Don't brake. Keep the wheel straight until the tires grip again.

Q What tire pressure is better for handling skids?

A The high side of the manufacturer's recommended range.

Q What are the warning signs of standing water?

A Reflections on the road, "dimples" from raindrops, a "slushing" sound from your tires, and a "loose" feel in the steering.

Q Should you use cruise control in the rain?

A Never, during or after rain.

Floods

Q What share of NC tropical-weather deaths since 1970 were caused by inland flooding?

A 85 percent. Half of those were people driving into roads they knew were flooded.

Q **Should you drive through standing water?**

A Never. It may be deeper than it looks, or the road may be washed out.

Q **How much fast-moving water can sweep a car off the road? How much can float it?**

A Six inches can sweep a car away. Twelve inches can float it or flip it.

Fog

Q **How should you drive in fog?**

A Use low beams, slow down, watch for the taillights ahead, and watch the cars behind you.

Q **What should you do if you can barely see in fog?**

A Pull far off the road, stop and turn on your flashers. Get out on the passenger side and stay away from the road.

Snow & Ice

Q **Which spots freeze first?**

A Shady spots, bridges and overpasses.

Q **How should you drive in a snowstorm?**

A Slow down, use your wipers and turn on your low beams.

Q **How much should you slow down on packed snow? On ice?**

A By more than half on packed snow. Slow to a crawl on ice.

Q **How should you start and stop on snow or ice?**

A Do this:

- Speed up slowly.
- Test your steering and braking to get the "feel of the road."
- In a manual car, start in second gear or higher and let the clutch out slowly.
- Allow at least three times the normal stopping distance.
- Keep your foot off the brake and let the engine slow the car.
- Keep extra distance from the car ahead.

Q **Do chains and snow tires stop you from sliding on ice?**

A No. Even chains and snow tires can slide on ice and packed snow.

Wildlife

Q **Why are wildlife collisions increasing?**

A Growing developments cut through wildlife corridors. Animals then have to cross roads looking for food, water, shelter and mates.

Q **When is wildlife most active?**

A At dawn, at dusk and in the first few hours after dark. Also during spring and fall migrations.

Q **Why does slowing down help with wildlife?**

A It gives you and the animal more time to react. A deer hit at 35 mph is much less likely to be fatal, for the deer and the driver, than one hit at 55+ mph.

Q **What should you scan for at night to spot wildlife?**

A Movement and eye shine at the road edges. Ask passengers to help.

Q **Why are wildlife crossing signs placed where they are?**

A They mark known hot spots for wildlife collisions.

Q **When should you use high beams around wildlife?**

A Only when there's no oncoming traffic and no animal directly ahead. High beams can "freeze" animals ("deer in headlights").

Q **If you see one deer, what should you expect?**

A More animals nearby. Many species travel in groups, one behind another.

Q **How does littering affect wildlife crashes?**

A Trash draws animals closer to the road.

Q **What should you do if you see wildlife on the road?**

A Brake firmly, stay in your lane and try to stop. You can honk briefly.

Q **What should you do if you hit an animal or find an injured one?**

A Pull safely off the road. Stay in your car, lock the doors and turn on your hazards. Don't approach the animal. Report it to NCDOT at 1-877-368-4968 and to a local wildlife rehabilitator.

Emergencies

Q **What is the most important thing to do in an emergency?**

A Don't panic. React quickly and correctly.

Q **What should you do if your brakes fail in a manual car?**

A Shift to a lower gear, release the clutch and apply the emergency brake.

Q **What should you do if your brakes fail in an automatic car?**

A Apply the emergency brake and shift into low range.

Q **How do you dry wet brakes?**

A Drive a short distance while pressing the brake pedal lightly. The heat dries the brake linings.

Q **How do you avoid wearing out your brakes on a long downhill?**

A Use a lower gear instead of the brakes. Shift at the top of the hill.

Q **What should you do if your gas pedal sticks?**

A Tap the pedal or lift it with your foot. Shift to neutral and brake firmly without locking the wheels. Then get completely off the road.

Q How can you tell you've had a blowout?

A A loud noise, and the vehicle starts to swerve. If the ride feels bumpy for no clear reason, stop and check your tires.

Q What should you do during a blowout?

A Hold the wheel tightly and keep the car straight. Take your foot off the gas. Don't brake until the car has slowed enough for you to keep control. Then get off the road.

Q What precautions should you take before changing a flat tire?

A Do this:

- Get completely off the road.
- Set the parking brake.
- Use flares if you have them.
- Have passengers get out on the passenger side and move away from the road. Don't let them stand in front of or behind the car.
- Turn on your flashers and parking lights.
- Block the wheels.

Q Should you repair your car where it's exposed to traffic?

A No. Call a tow truck or a mechanic.

Q What should you do if your car breaks down?

A Pull completely onto the shoulder. Everyone gets out on the passenger side and stands off the road, away from the front and back of the car. Tie a white cloth to the left door handle or antenna and raise the hood. At night, use your parking lights or flashers. Keep flashlights or flares in the car.

Q What should you do if an oncoming car crosses into your lane?

A Slow down right away, honk, and keep to the right, even if it means leaving the road.

Q What should you do if your car runs off the pavement onto the shoulder?

A Don't brake hard or jerk the wheel back. Ease off the gas, steer straight, and let the car slow down. When you're nearly stopped and it's clear, ease back onto the road.

Skids

Q Which road conditions most often cause skids?

A Wet roads, ice and packed snow.

Q How do you brake on slick roads to avoid a skid?

A Slow down gradually. With ABS, use firm, steady pressure and don't pump. Without ABS, pump the brakes gently.

Q What should you do in a skid?

A Ease off the gas and steer in the direction the rear of the car is sliding. As the car straightens, turn the wheel back so you don't over-steer.

Crashes

Q **Are people who stop to help at a crash protected by law?**

A Yes. They are protected from civil liability, except for intentional wrongdoing or unruly conduct.

Q **What should you do if a crash seems likely?**

A Honk, keep to the right, and turn away from oncoming traffic. Drive off the road, into an open field if you can.

Q **What should you do if you're about to be hit from behind and nothing is in front of you?**

A Speed up and get away if you can, but be ready to brake. Brace yourself between the wheel and the seat, and press your head against the headrest.

Q **What should you do if you're about to be hit?**

A Grip the wheel tightly and be ready to turn quickly to keep control. If all else fails, protect your face from broken glass with your arms and hands.

Q **What must you do if you're in a crash?**

A Stop right away, which the law requires. Prevent more crashes at the scene, help anyone hurt, and make sure police are told.

Q **When should vehicles be moved out of the travel lane after a crash?**

A When no one is hurt or killed and the cars can be driven safely, move them onto the shoulder. This applies on a main lane, ramp, shoulder or median.

Q **When must you report a crash to police right away?**

A When anyone is killed or injured, or the total property damage looks like $1,000 or more.

Q **What can happen if you don't report a crash?**

A You can be prosecuted, and your license may be suspended.

Q **Who else should you report a crash to?**

A Your insurance company. In some cases, you must also file proof of liability insurance with DMV.

Q **What three things must you do after a crash?**

A

1. Give your name, address, license number, registration number and insurance company.
2. Get the same information from the others involved.
3. If you can't find the other owner, such as for a parked car or damaged property, write down everything you can and give it to the police.

Chapter 5 — Signals, Signs and Pavement Markings

Traffic Signals

Q **What does a circular green light mean?**

A Go carefully, straight or turning. Turning vehicles must yield to oncoming traffic and pedestrians.

Q **What does a circular yellow light mean?**

A Caution: the light is about to turn red. Stop unless you are too close to stop safely. Never speed up to "beat" the red.

Q **What does a steady red light mean?**

A STOP. Unless a "NO TURN ON RED" sign is posted, you may turn right after a complete stop, yielding to traffic and pedestrians.

Q **What is the penalty for not yielding to a pedestrian when turning right on red?**

A $100 to $500.

Q **What does a green arrow mean?**

A A "protected" turn. You may go carefully in the direction of the arrow.

Q **When both have green arrows, who yields: a U-turning car or an opposing right-turning car?**

A The U-turning car yields to the right-turning car.

Q **What does a red arrow mean?**

A Turning traffic must stop.

Q **What does a yellow arrow mean?**

A The protected green arrow is about to change to a circular green, circular red or red arrow.

Q **When both arrows and circular lights are shown, what controls what?**

A Arrows control turning traffic. Circular lights control through traffic.

Q **What should you do at a traffic light that isn't working (for example, a power outage)?**

A Treat it like an all-way stop, unless an officer is directing traffic or another control device is working.

Q **What does a flashing red light mean?**

A The same as a stop sign. Stop, and go only when it's safe.

Q **What does a flashing yellow light mean?**

A Slow down and go with caution, like a warning sign.

Q **What does a flashing yellow arrow mean?**

A You may turn, but you must yield to oncoming traffic and pedestrians.

Q **What does a solid yellow arrow mean on a flashing-yellow-arrow signal?**

A Get ready to stop.

Q What does a solid red arrow mean?

A Stop. No turns are allowed.

Q What does a solid green arrow mean on a flashing-yellow-arrow signal?

A You may turn without yielding to oncoming traffic. Still go with caution.

Q What is a ramp meter?

A A signal that controls traffic entering a freeway from an on-ramp.

Q What do you do at a ramp meter that is red, green or dark?

A Red: stop and wait for green. Green: go down the ramp and merge. Dark: go without stopping and merge as normal.

Q Where are hybrid beacons used?

A At mid-block crosswalks and at the entrances of emergency response stations.

Q What is the hybrid beacon sequence?

A

1. Dark until a pedestrian or emergency crew activates it.
2. Flashing yellow.
3. Steady yellow.
4. Steady red: stop while pedestrians cross or emergency vehicles come out.
5. Flashing red: stay stopped until they clear. Then, after a complete stop, you may go.
6. Dark again.

Traffic Signs

Q What are the three types of traffic signs?

A Regulatory, warning, and guide/informational.

Q How can you recognize signs at a glance?

A By their shape and color.

Q What shape is a stop sign, and what colors?

A An eight-sided octagon with white letters on red. This shape is used only for stop signs.

Q How far from the intersection is a stop sign usually placed?

A 6 to 50 feet.

Q Where must you stop at a stop sign or signal?

A At the marked stop line. If there's none, stop before the crosswalk. If there's no crosswalk either, stop before entering the intersection, where you can see the cross street.

Q What shape and color is a yield sign?

A A triangle with the point down, in red and white.

Q What must you do at a yield sign?

A Slow down and yield the right of way. Stop if needed for traffic on the cross street.

Q What shapes and colors are speed limit and other regulatory signs?

A Rectangles or squares, usually black and white or red and white. Examples are "NO U-TURN" and "KEEP RIGHT EXCEPT TO PASS."

Q What does the handicap parking sign mean?

A The space is only for vehicles showing a handicap plate or placard.

Q What is the pennant-shaped yellow sign?

A A no-passing zone sign. It sits on the left side of the road and points to where the no-passing zone (solid yellow line in your lane) begins.

Q What do diamond-shaped signs mean?

A Warning or caution. They are black on yellow, or black on orange for construction and maintenance zones.

Q When is a "STOP AHEAD" sign used?

A Far ahead of a stop sign, when a curve or other object blocks your view of it.

Q What does a round yellow sign with a black X and "RR" mean?

A Advance warning of a railroad crossing. Slow down, and stop if needed.

Q What is the crossbuck sign?

A The white X-shaped sign that reads "RAILROAD CROSSING," placed at the crossing itself. A sign below it shows multiple tracks.

Q How many times should you look each way before crossing railroad tracks?

A Twice in each direction.

Q What does the five-sided (pentagon) sign mean?

A A school zone or school crossing. Watch for children. The speed limit may be lower during school hours.

Q What does the "DO NOT STOP ON TRACKS" sign mean?

A Never stop on the railroad tracks for any reason.

Guide/Informational Signs & Route Markers

Q What do guide/informational signs show?

A Directions, routes, distances and services.

Q Which way do odd-numbered highways run? Even-numbered?

A Odd numbers run north–south. Even numbers run east–west.

Q What shape are U.S. highway markers?

A A shield.

Q What shape are NC route markers?

A A diamond.

Q What shape are NC secondary road signs?

A Rectangular.

Q How are interstate highways marked?

A With a red, white and blue shield.

Q What color are signs for hospitals, Highway Patrol stations and telephones?

A Blue and white.

Q What colors are guide signs?

A Green, brown or blue (rectangular).

Q What should you do if you need time to read a sign or figure out where you are?

A Never stop in the road. Pull onto the shoulder when it's safe.

Pavement Markings

Q What do yellow lines separate? White lines?

A Yellow lines separate traffic going in opposite directions. White lines separate traffic going the same direction.

Q What does a broken (skipped) yellow center line mean?

A Passing with care is allowed in both directions.

Q What does a double solid yellow line mean?

A No passing in either direction.

Q On a two-lane road, when may you pass?

A When the broken yellow line is on your side.

Q What does a solid white line on the right edge of the road mean?

A It marks the right edge of the road. Solid white lines also guide traffic going the same direction.

Q What does a solid yellow line on the left edge of a divided highway mean?

A The left edge. If you see yellow on your right and white on your left, you're going the wrong way.

Q What is a two-way left-turn lane, and what can't you use it for?

A A center lane for left turns in both directions. Don't use it for passing or for merging into traffic.

Q What are reflective pavement markers for?

A White and yellow markers make lines easier to see at night in the rain. Red markers mean you're going the wrong way. Blue markers show nearby fire hydrants or water supplies.

Traffic Officers

Q If an officer is directing traffic, do you follow the officer or the signals?

A The officer.

Q How does an officer signal you to stop?

A One hand held up, palm toward you, with a long whistle blast.

Q How does an officer signal you to go?

A A hand motion with a series of short whistle blasts. At night they may use a flashlight.

Chapter 6 — Sharing the Road

Bicycles

Q **Are bicycles vehicles under NC law?**

A Yes. Bicyclists must obey the same traffic laws as drivers, including DWI laws.

Q **Can bicyclists use the full travel lane?**

A Yes, when traffic conditions require it. Drivers should expect bicyclists in the road.

Q **Where may bicyclists choose to ride?**

A In bike lanes, on paved shoulders, or in regular travel lanes. They choose based on road conditions, hazards and right-turning traffic.

Q **Like drivers, what must bicyclists do?**

A Ride on the right side of the road, stop for stop signs and red lights, and use hand signals.

Q **When may you pass a bicyclist?**

A Only when there is plenty of room and no oncoming traffic. The safest way is to change lanes. Follow the passing laws (NCGS 20-149 and 20-150).

Q **Which direction should bicyclists ride?**

A With traffic, never against it. Drivers often don't look for bicyclists riding the wrong way.

Q **What lights must a bicycle have at night?**

A A front light visible from at least 300 feet, and a red rear light or reflector visible from at least 200 feet.

Q **Where can you expect bicyclists?**

A On all roads, except where they are expressly banned.

Q **Name three common car–bicycle crash types to avoid.**

A The left cross, the drive-out, and the right hook.

Q **Who must wear a bicycle helmet?**

A All riders and passengers under 16. They must also sit on a saddle seat.

Q **Which bicycle passengers must sit in a bicycle restraining seat?**

A Passengers under 40 pounds or under 40 inches tall.

Q **How can you contact the NCDOT Bicycle & Pedestrian Division?**

A Call 919-707-2600, visit www.ncdot.gov/bikeped, or write to 1552 Mail Service Center, Raleigh, NC 27699-1552.

You as a Pedestrian

Q **In cities, what share of people killed in vehicle crashes are pedestrians? In rural areas?**

A About two of every five in cities, and about one of every ten in rural areas.

Q **Which pedestrians are most often killed?**

A Children, elderly people, and people who have been drinking.

Q **Which side of the road should pedestrians walk on?**

A The left side, facing traffic.

Q **How can pedestrians make themselves more visible?**

A Wear or carry something white, and carry a flashlight at night. Don't assume drivers can see you, and be ready to get out of the way.

Trucks & No-Zones

Q **Why is a large truck harder to drive than a car?**

A Trucks speed up slowly, especially uphill, and often look slower than they are. They need extra room to turn because the rear wheels don't follow the front wheels. Their brakes heat up going downhill, so they need more distance to stop.

Q **What should you check before passing a tractor-trailer that seems to be turning left?**

A Which way the driver is signaling.

Q **How can a large truck affect your steering?**

A Its wind currents can push your car. Give trucks plenty of room.

Q **What are "No-Zones"?**

A A truck's blind spots, where a car can disappear from view:

- up to 20 feet in front of the cab
- along both sides, especially beside the cab
- up to 200 feet behind

Q **What's the rule of thumb for truck blind spots?**

A "If you can't see the truck driver in their side mirror, they can't see you."

RVs & Trailers

Q **How are RVs different from cars?**

A They are longer, taller and wider. They speed up and stop more slowly, need more room to turn, block your view more the closer you get, and have bigger blind spots.

Q **What should you watch for near a vehicle towing a trailer?**

A Swaying, crosswinds and slippery curves. Sudden braking can make the trailer jackknife.

Q How much clear road might you need to pass a vehicle towing a trailer?

A About half a mile.

Motorcycles & Mopeds

Q Are motorcycles entitled to the full width of their lane?

A Yes. To pass one, change lanes just as you would for a car.

Q Where should a moped ride, and how far must you stay from it when passing?

A On the right side of the lane. Pass at least two feet to the left.

Q Why must you leave cyclists plenty of room when passing?

A So your car's wind doesn't make them lose control.

Q When should you be especially careful to look for motorcycles and mopeds?

A When turning, changing lanes at intersections, pulling out of a driveway, and especially when turning left.

Q What share of NC motorcycle crashes involve a car? Who is usually at fault?

A About two-thirds. The car driver is usually at fault, and usually says they didn't see the motorcycle.

Q What helmet must moped riders and passengers wear?

A An FMVSS 218 helmet, with the strap fastened.

Q When do motorcycles take longer to stop?

A When carrying a second rider, or on poor road surfaces.

Q Which road materials can make a motorcyclist lose control?

A Sand, gravel, wet leaves and water.

Q What are signs of a beginning motorcyclist?

A Wobbling or jerking when starting, or hesitating at traffic decisions. Give them extra room.

Q What should you remember around motorcycles and mopeds?

A Do this:

- Never crowd them.
- Follow farther back on slippery roads.
- Give them room at railroad crossings and on rough roads.
- Leave space on steel bridge joints and metal grating, which are hazardous for them.

Q How does NC law define a moped?

A A vehicle with two or three wheels, a motor of no more than 50cc, and no external shifting device.

Q What is a moped's legal top speed?

A 30 mph. Mopeds that go faster are illegal in NC.

Q What do you need to ride a moped on a public road?

A You must be at least 16 and have a valid NC driver license or NC ID card. DWI laws also apply.

Q What are the tips for riding a moped?

A The tips are:

- Avoid heavy traffic.
- Keep your distance and stay to the right of the lane.
- Let others pass, and don't share lanes.
- Never squeeze between parked cars and moving traffic.
- Wear bright clothing.
- Use turn signals or hand signals.
- Look far ahead, and stop and look before crossing traffic.
- Look over your shoulder before entering traffic.
- Wear protective clothing and shoes.

Q Must mopeds be registered, and since when?

A Yes, since July 2015. You need a registration card and a rear license plate.

Q How much is moped registration?

A $29.50 a year. Durham ($15), Orange ($15), Randolph ($1) and Wake ($5) counties add a transit tax.

Q What do you need to register a moped?

A You must be 16 or older, with a valid NC license or ID. You also need the manufacturer's certificate of origin (MCO), or form MVR-58 (Affidavit of Facts) if you don't have the MCO.

Litter & Adopt-A-Highway

Q Who is responsible when litter is thrown or blown from a vehicle?

A The driver.

Q What is the fine for littering?

A $250 to $1,000. A second offense within three years is $500 to $2,000.

Q When did Adopt-A-Highway start, and how big is it?

A April 1988. More than 4,500 groups have adopted about 9,000 miles of roadside.

Q What does an Adopt-A-Highway group agree to do?

A Pick up litter at least four times a year along a two-mile stretch of state road.

Q What does NCDOT provide to Adopt-A-Highway groups?

A Two signs recognizing the group, plus safety vests and training. Groups are asked to recycle what they collect.

Q How can you learn more about Adopt-A-Highway?

A Visit www.ncdot.gov/beautification or call 919-707-2970.

Chapter 7 — How DMV Serves You

Q **What is the DMV responsible for?**

A Promoting highway safety and serving NC citizens through its driver license, vehicle registration and vehicle inspection programs.

Driver Records

Q **Where can you get a copy of your driving record?**

A You can get it:

- online at NCDMV.gov
- at Raleigh Central Services, 4121 New Bern Ave. (use the "Vehicle Registration" door, not "Driver License")
- at the Huntersville License Plate Agency, 12101 Mt. Holly-Huntersville Road

Q **Which form must you complete before getting your driving record?**

A The Driver Privacy Protection Act Request Form (DL-DPPA-I).

Q **How much do driving records cost?**

A The prices are:

- certified copy: $18 (available online)
- non-certified full history: $12.75 (available online)
- 3-year history: $12.75 (not online)
- 7-year history: $12.75 (not online)
- address history: $16.75 (not online)

Q **What are 3- and 7-year records used for? Certified records?**

A 3- and 7-year records are usually for insurance and jobs. Certified records are usually for court.

Q **Who do you make the check out to, and where do you mail a record request?**

A Make it payable to NCDMV. Mail it to NC Division of Motor Vehicles, Driver License DR Unit, 3133 Mail Service Center, Raleigh, NC 27697-3113.

Vehicle Registration

Q **What must you have before titling or registering a vehicle in NC?**

A An NC driver license.

Q **Which vehicles don't need to be registered?**

A Exempt farm vehicles and exempt road construction equipment.

Q **What does a new resident need to title and register a vehicle?**

A Their valid out-of-state license plus their NC Temporary Driving Certificate (TDC).

Q How do you register a vehicle?

A Fill out the application forms and pay the title and registration fees.

Q What does DMV give you when you register?

A A registration card, a license plate and validation stickers.

Q Where must the registration card be kept?

A In the vehicle at all times, ready to show an officer.

Q What does the license plate show?

A The vehicle's unique number, the registration expiration date, and that it's registered in NC.

Q Are plastic license plate covers allowed?

A No (G.S. 20-63g).

Q What do you need to change your registration address online, and what does it cost?

A Your plate number, the last five characters of your title number and an email address. It's free. If your registration is expired, you renew and change the address together for the normal renewal fee.

Q How long do you have to tell DMV about a name change for your registration, and where?

A 60 days, at a driver license office.

Q What must you do within 60 days of moving within NC?

A Update your address and get a duplicate license or ID. If you own a vehicle, also order a duplicate registration card.

Q What proof of ownership is needed to register a vehicle?

A It depends on the vehicle:

- New vehicle: the manufacturer's certificate of origin.
- Used vehicle already registered in NC: the title, properly signed over by the former owner.
- Used vehicle from another state: that state's title.
- Used vehicle from a non-title state: the registration card with a notarized transfer, or a notarized bill of sale plus the former owner's proof of purchase.

Q When can an out-of-state license or ID be used to register a vehicle?

A With documentation of any of these:

- active military duty in NC
- school enrollment in NC
- the vehicle kept in NC for at least six months
- a court-ordered sale
- co-ownership where one owner has an NC license or ID
- a motor home registration
- a documented medical condition

Q Must the vehicle's inspection be valid to register it?

A Yes.

Insurance & Financial Responsibility

Q What must an owner certify before a vehicle can be registered?

A That it is covered by liability insurance.

Q What forms of financial responsibility are accepted?

A A liability policy from an NC-licensed insurer, cash or a bond deposited with the State Treasurer, or self-insurance for fleets of 25 or more vehicles.

Q What are NC's minimum liability insurance amounts?

A The minimums are:

- $30,000 for injury to one person
- $60,000 for all injuries in a crash
- $25,000 for property damage
- $750,000 for a commercial vehicle

Q What can happen if DMV learns you're driving without insurance?

A Your plate can be revoked for 30 days unless you prove continuous coverage. You may also face a fine or penalty.

Q How long must you keep liability insurance?

A Continuously, for as long as the vehicle has a valid license plate.

Q When do liability policies start and end?

A They start at 12:01 a.m. on the date issued and last six months, ending at 12:01 a.m.

Q Does NC honor an insurance grace period?

A No. A grace period is only an agreement between you and your insurer.

Q How do you avoid a penalty when cancelling insurance?

A Turn in your license plate before the insurance ends.

Registration Renewal

Q When must a vehicle be inspected before its registration renews?

A Within 90 days before the registration expires.

Q What does DMV issue when you renew your registration?

A Plate stickers showing the new registration and inspection period.

Q What is a staggered registration system?

A Renewals are spread over all 12 months of the year.

Transfers & Lost Documents

Q How do you transfer ownership of a vehicle?

A Use section "A" on side two of the title. Sign it in front of a notary, and actually deliver the vehicle to the new owner.

Q What inspection is needed when a vehicle is sold and a plate will be requested?

A A current inspection within the last 12 months before the sale.

Q When can you move license plates to another vehicle?

A When the new vehicle is the same category, owned in the same name, and the insurance has been continuous.

Q How long after applying until you can get a duplicate title?

A At least 15 days after DMV gets the application and fee.

Q How do you replace a lost registration card?

A Pay the fee and apply at a vehicle registration office or online.

Tag & Tax Together

Q What is "Tag & Tax Together"?

A A law requiring you to pay your registration renewal and your vehicle property tax at the same time, in one payment. Both must be paid in full to renew.

Q Who sets a vehicle's value for property tax?

A The local county assessment office, based on make and model. DMV does not.

Q Which vehicles are excluded from Tag & Tax Together?

A These are excluded:

- vehicles exempt from registration
- manufactured homes
- mobile classrooms and offices
- multi-year semi-trailers
- vehicles owned or leased by public service companies
- park model trailers
- mopeds

Q What are the three ways to pay Tag & Tax?

A Online at NCDMV.gov, at a local License Plate Agency (usually 9 a.m. to 5 p.m., Monday–Friday), or by mail to P.O. Box 29620, Raleigh, NC 27626.

Q What is an "instant title"?

A A faster titling service, with titles issued the same day or the next business day at certain offices.

Inspections

Q How often must NC vehicles be inspected?

A Every year.

Q Who oversees vehicle inspections?

A The DMV License & Theft Bureau.

Q What must a vehicle pass before it can be registered or renewed?

A A safety-only inspection, or a safety and emissions inspection.

Q How early can you get an inspection?

A Up to 90 days before your registration expires.

Q What if your vehicle fails inspection?

A You can be re-inspected at the same station within 60 days for free.

Q How many NC counties require emissions inspections?

A 19.

Q Which vehicles get a safety-only inspection, with no emissions test?

A Vehicles within the three most recent model years that have less than 70,000 miles.

Q Where can you find your vehicle's model year?

A On your registration card, under "YEAR."

Q In emissions counties, which model years need emissions testing?

A 1996 and newer.

Q What is the extra inspection fee for after-factory window tint?

A $10.

Q What is the minimum light transmittance for tinted windows?

A 35%.

Back Cover

Q **When was the handbook last revised?**

A May 2025. Laws and fees can be changed by the NC General Assembly.

Q **Where is DMV Headquarters? Does it offer license or registration services?**

A 1515 N. Church Street, Rocky Mount, NC 27804. It offers no license, ID, title or registration services.

Q **How many handbooks were printed, and at what cost?**

A 75,000 copies, costing $66,750 total, or $0.89 each.